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WINCHESTER *RECLAIMED* —

From Gun Factory to Luxury Lofts

The Politic

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No Haven *for the* Homeless

BY **RITA WANG**

According to Bob, New Haven is the best city in the United States.

"People come here from all over the United States just to sit on the Green," he said.

Wearing a loose white tank, sporting a gray beard, and casually drinking beer out of a brown paper bag, he refused my offer of a banana.

"I just had one," he remarked.

Walking on the Green on a beautiful Friday afternoon, I was presented with two sides of the same story. Before meeting Bob, I had met another homeless man, also coincidentally named Bob. Sitting on the bench near Center Church, picking at his toes as his shopping cart full of valuables sat close by, he shared his thoughts on homelessness in New Haven with me.

"It's getting better. The programs are working. I think there are less people on the Green than two years ago," observed the second Bob.

He said that a lot of people were getting housing, and that occasionally, policemen ask him to move for loitering, but it is okay because "I'm not supposed to be there anyway."

Having just come back from City Hall with a 104 page packet entirely full of homelessness resources, he inspired in me a renewed faith in government programs. Maybe community policing and community-centered initiatives could work. But my encounters with the people on the next bench over told a different story.

"It's very hard," a thin black woman in a red hoodie confessed, taking the banana I offered her but declining to give her name. "It rained yesterday, and that was very hard."

I asked her if she could go to a shelter. She told me that shelters, while they offer a place to sleep at night, must be vacated by 7:30 a.m. Bedbugs are everywhere, and there is a lot of stealing—homeless people from each other and sometimes even shelter employees from the homeless people. Although he has only been in New Haven since May, the first Bob has had his things stolen from him eleven times.

Yale students are always told to be wary of the Green, especially at night. Yale Police Chief Ronnell Higgins demonstrates safety awareness to freshmen by showing a film where an angry old man in a suit pops out of random places lamenting the lack of alertness Yale students have for both their valuables and their surroundings. The not-so-subtle implication of the video is that Yale students should be wary of the New Haven outside Yale's gates, and a three-yard walk from Old Campus reveals the jarring dichotomy between the opulent university and the town park, where students rarely venture.

The city seems to be moving toward a less tolerant policy in regards to the homeless, with the increase of community policing and the possible beginning of a new policy that would push homeless people out of New Haven.

DURING YALE FRESHMAN move-in day, the New Haven Police moved all the homeless people off the Green, preventing many homeless from reaching soup kitchens. Yale President Peter Salovey and the Office of New Haven and State Affairs denied that this is a Yale-approved policy. However, the city seems to be moving toward a less tolerant policy in regards to the homeless, with the increase of community policing and the possible beginning of a new policy that would push homeless people out of New Haven. At any given time, there are about 556 chronically homeless people total in the city of New Haven, of which 22 percent are children in families and 52 percent have a history of substance abuse. Despite these numbers, New Haven has been trying

to pass ordinances that would criminalize the status of being homeless.

In 2014, an Open Space Ordinance was proposed that would have put opening and closing hours on all of the parks in New Haven, including the Green. The ordinance would have created a permit system for all events in parks and limited the construction of "temporary structures and shelters." Corporate Counsel Victor Bolden, the attorney designated to give legal advice to the Board of Alders and a prominent supporter of the Open Space Ordinance, pushed for a section in the ordinance that would have made it illegal for anyone to stay on the Green after 10 p.m., effectively preventing the homeless from sleeping on the Green.

The ordinance was given a "leave to withdraw"—the polite way of saying the Board of Alders voted it down due to worries that would have negative consequences for the homeless. These concerns were raised after considerable outrage from the community and organizations that help the homeless, including a petition that garnered five hundred signatures. However, renewed efforts have tried to bring back the ordinance due to the perceived decline of the Green.

EACH MORNING, PILES of needles, human feces, and urine are found around the area surrounding Trinity Episcopal Church on the Green. In September, Mayor Toni Harp visited the Green and was "appalled by the condition," according to Rev. Dr. Luk De Volder. The Trinity Episcopal Church on the Green spends a significant amount of money each year trying to clean up the mess. But rather than support the Open Space Ordinance, church members have been in the process of writing a letter to Mayor Harp asking her to protect the homeless people on the Green. They have also organized several community "Clean up the Green" events in an effort to beautify the space.

Mark Colville of La Amistad Catholic Worker, who was strongly against the ordinance in 2014, is worried about the renewed interest in the ordinance.

"We hold the same position from last time," he told *The Politic*. "The ordinance criminalizes the status of being poor. It won't solve homelessness and also creates unfair racial and economic profiling."

Colville believes that the poor and homeless are not to blame for Trinity Church's troubles on the Green, and that the blame lies with the out-of-towners that come every weekend to go to New Haven's night clubs. He also expressed frustration at how unresponsive the Harp administration has been toward the homeless in New Haven. During discussions with the administration, he was told that the mayor did not have an answer to the question of homelessness, and that administration officials brushed the matter off as a regional problem that was not New Haven's responsibility to solve. The mayoral department that oversees most of the homeless rehabilitation and reintegration programs declined to comment.

Bureaucracy also complicates things for many of the sitters on the Green by preventing them from getting housing. The Captain, an older man with a long white beard and a baseball cap that makes him resemble the famed Captain Phillips, has applied multiple times for disability housing due to his arthritic leg and has been rejected each time. But he has a lawyer now, and he hopes that the lawyer finally will help him to get his disability checks; he finds it harder and harder to walk the three miles every day from the shelter to the Green with his bad foot.

AFTER POLICE CHIEF Dean Esserman took office four years ago, walking beats were brought back as part of a new focus on "community policing," intended to foster better relationships between the officers and



the communities they serve. However, the program has not worked out well. Policemen arbitrarily decide to apply laws to the homeless people on the Green and in the surrounding shops. When Bob—the first Bob—tried to go to the bathroom at Starbucks, an officer prevented him, as all of the shops in downtown New Haven are technically for customers only.

When I talked to him, Bob refused to be identified because he was afraid the New Haven Police would arrest him. He told me that he was thrown on the ground by a police officer and handcuffed for looking through the trash to find empty bottles to sell. Just that morning, he had almost been arrested for theft because he had an unmarked shopping cart that had been given to him. Bob feels discriminated against, and thinks that the arbitrary application of laws is because of an implicit bias against the homeless in the city.

> "It would be great if students would feel comfortable enough to just have picnics on the Green, fly kites, and talk to us...Yale students have been the kindest to me, always helping me out and bringing me food and clothing."



It's not just the police. Bob, a veteran, has had his things stolen from him eleven times within the past four months, including his ID. While he sleeps on the Green, he is often woken up forcefully by biker gangs. He showed me gruesome scars on his head from the last beating.

Bob is extremely unhappy with the dehumanization of homeless people and is tired of people who blame him for his circumstances. While drugs and alcohol contribute to the homeless problem, Bob is not addicted to either. Another man I met on the Green that day, Kent Goosdy, is homeless because he lost his 401k. Neither Bob nor Kent is from Connecticut. They both came to New Haven because of the Green's lack of opening and closing hours, a beneficial policy for the homeless who often have nowhere else to sleep.

The homeless population on the Green has declined in the past two years. But the decrease may be due to increased contempt for homeless people that, in turn, pushes them out of the city. But there are ways to challenge the dehumanization of the homeless, starting from within the ivory tower itself.

"It would be great if Yale students would feel comfortable enough to just have picnics on the Green, fly kites, and talk to us," Kent told *The Politic*. "Yale students have been the kindest to me, always helping me out and bringing me food and clothing."

He also brought up the ideas of holding lectures or discussions where homeless people could talk about their experiences and give Yale students first-hand accounts of the effects of economic and social inequality.

"You are the younger generation that can help make changes in the system," Kent concluded. "Never forget that."

an ASPIRATIONAL democracy

BY **MAGGIE MOOR**

"It's amazing how much has changed. It is a huge deal that there is even a choice in who to elect,"

said Myanmar native Phyu Lwin '18. "I don't know what will happen. I have an equal amount of optimism and cynicism. But there is always hope."

To understand the implications of the upcoming elections in Myanmar, Lwin implied that looking backward is just as important as looking forward.

In 1989, officials in Myanmar declared martial law. The economy was in shambles and pro-democracy riots overtook the country. In that same year, Aung San Suu Kyi began her house arrest. Her father led the rebellion that founded the nation. Her mother served as ambassador to India. Educated at Oxford, employed by the U.N., winner of the Nobel Peace Prize and a revolutionary in her own right, Suu Kyi is beloved by her people. In 1990, her party, the National League for Democracy (NLD), won 85% percent of the popular vote. But those results were ignored. In protest of the military junta that denied her people sovereignty, economic prosperity, and a voice, she spent 15 of the next 21 years in custody. November 8 will mark the first general election in which she is free. She leads the opposition, yet she cannot seek the presidency.

A country slightly smaller than Texas, located at the vital intersection between China, India and the Indian Ocean, the British colonized what was then Burma in the late 1800s. After decades of oppression, Suu Kyi's father launched a campaign for independence during World War II, which

succeeded in 1948. However, peace was not so easily secured. Divisions within the ruling political party led the military to stage a socialist coup in 1962.

So began decades of seclusion and conflict. After nearly half a century in isolation, however, the military government announced its desire to reenter the world economy. In 2010, elections to establish a democratic system were held. But the NLD refused to participate in what were widely seen as sham elections, since Suu Kyi remained captive. So the Union Solidarity and Development Party (USDP), a newly created political party composed of former generals and junta government officials, claimed victory. One week later, the USDP released Suu Kyi. They had the power, and she was not a threat. The technical reign of the military junta had ended, but make no mistake — the "democratically elected" government was merely the same military power under a new title.

Over the next two years, the USDP government made strides toward reform. As evidence of increasing openness to change, the NLD won all but one of the contested parliamentary seats in the 2012 bi-elections, with Suu Kyi claiming a seat in the lower house. The people began to hope that the 2015 elections would bring a peaceful transition to a coalition government between the NLD and USDP.

"I am frustratingly optimistic," said David Steinberg, Distinguished Professor of Asian Studies at Georgetown University and author of numerous books on Myanmar, at a Carnegie Endowment for International Peace panel on the elections this past June.

But in the dark hours of August 12, 2015, on what seemed to be a typical Wednesday night, a group of trucks pulled up to the headquarters of the USDP. Without warning, soldiers and police officers stormed out of their vehicles and took control of the compound. By 2:30 a.m., the security forces had left. Their job was complete. Shwe Mann was out.

As the former third most powerful man in the junta government and USDP party chairman, Thura Shwe Mann may not appear to be a typical ally of democratic change. Yet in the past few years, his efforts to remove power from the military spurred an informal alliance with Suu Kyi and thrust his name forth into the conversation for president. He became a symbol of reform, made more powerful by his substantial military history. He also became a threat to the USDP establishment. Dividing the USDP between liberal and conservative, and endangering current President Thein Sein's rule, Shwe Mann was removed from the party leadership by a combined military-USDP force. The official story? He was "too busy" to remain in power.

The government has shown for over a century how little they care for the people's will. This is a reflection of that.

For many, Shwe Mann's removal casts a shadow of doubt over formerly optimistic predictions for the elections.

"The government has shown for over a century how little they care for the people's will. This is a reflection of that," Lwin told *The Politic*.

Assistant Secretary of State Daniel Russel echoed these feelings, claiming that the ousting had a "chilling effect on the political climate."

Yet Shwe Mann is still running for reelection on the USDP ticket and remains Speaker of the Lower House, as his allies stand with him against threats of impeachment. Priscilla Clapp, former Chief of Mission at the US Embassy in Myanmar, believes that Shwe Mann's ousting is of little consequence to the overall outcome of the upcoming elections.

"Many people are overreacting to Shwe Mann's removal. We can't expect the elections to be entirely free and fair because the government doesn't know how to do that," Clapp told *The Politic*. "Shwe Mann liberalized the USDP. It's not just good guys versus bad guys anymore. The uniformed military of parliament and ex-military of the USDP are different things. Parts of the party will gravitate towards the NLD."

Vikram Nehru, a senior associate at the Carnegie Endowment for International Peace and leader of the Carnegie events series Myanmar Votes 2015, sees the leadership change more as a reflec-

tion of how removed the military is.

"I don't think the current leadership has necessarily internalized what democratic elections mean," he told *The Politic*.

"Even if the military wanted to change candidates, they must still stand for election. They are dealing with a different sort of politics from before."

While it may be a different sort of politics, relics of the old regime are present throughout the system. Myanmar's elections are two-fold. On November 8, the offices of local representatives and national members of parliament will be selected. One quarter of the parliament, however, will not be elected by the people. Because of a controversial provision in the constitution, 25 percent of parliament seats are reserved for military appointments. And without somehow achieving 75 percent support in parliament and winning a national referendum, that will not change.

Once elected, committees of representatives from the upper and lower houses and the military forces in parliament each nominate a candidate for president. All members of parliament vote among the three, and the candidate who receives the most votes takes office while the other two serve as vice presidents. In what is seen as a targeted addition to the 2008 constitution, it is forbidden for anyone whose spouse or children are foreign citizens to hold the office. Unsurprisingly, Suu Kyi's husband and two sons hold British passports.

"I don't think the current leadership has necessarily internalized what democratic elections mean. Even if the military wanted to change candidates, they must still stand for election."

Strong ties with Myanmar are key to advancing U.S. interests in Asia, especially given its strategic location. In preparation for and in support of the elections, the U.S. is funding numerous development initiatives.

Assistant Secretary of State Russel stated, "We are providing more than $18 million to strengthen Burma's democratic institutions, to support the development of civil society, political parties and the media, and to assist the government in conducting the elections."

Jonathan Stonestreet, associate director of the Carter Center Democracy Program, is managing their Myanmar mission. Funded in part by the United States Agency for International Development (USAID), the mission is focused on monitoring the political transition and election process, from examining the role of ethnic minorities and gender to the registration of candidates and voter education. They will deploy between 30 and 40 short-term international observers on Election Day to collect data on the integrity of various polling locations.

Stonestreet told *The Politic* how impressed he was by the "unprecedented and unexpected access the observers have had so far," and sees this as an indicator of the government's efforts to uphold its promise of fair elections.

Yet Liza Prendergast, Director of Business Development at Democracy International, emphasized caution. "The international community has very high expectations. The U.S. should go in with an understanding that the elections themselves are a huge step, and they may or may not live up to international standards," she told *The Politic*.

Clapp explained to *The Politic* the importance of the elections to U.S. policy. "If the NLD wins by a significant amount, we will see a major impact on US policy. We will need to free our own hands by removing legislative restrictions and be more active in helping develop institutions."

However, if the NLD is not seen as successful in challenging the USDP, Clapp claims that U.S. policy will not change significantly. "Maybe some restrictions will be put back on. But as long as the opposition is alive, the US will not pull back far."

As a country with a dark history, still emerging from intense civil war, Myanmar is taking its first of many steps toward increasing transparency, building trust, and maintaining peace. The results of these elections will set Myanmar's course within the international community. But for now, as Clapp put it, Myanmar remains an aspirational democracy.

Saving the Stateless

The Uphill Effort to Resettle Refugees

BY **CLARA COLLIER**

Ahmed* was the perfect candidate for resettlement. He fled Iraq for Malaysia in 2007, after working for an American company in Baghdad. There, while completing a master's degree in information technology, he began to apply for refugee status in the United States. Like all Iraqis who aided the U.S. military and can't return to their home country safely, Ahmed was eligible for a Special Immigration Visa. There was no security risk—he'd already been vetted in Baghdad. His education made him highly employable.

The process took two years.

"The process to come here, it's long and complicated," he told *The Politic*. "It's not an easy thing to do. Some people I know, they waited five or six years. I think I was lucky, just by doing it in two."

Now, Ahmed lives in New Haven. When we spoke over the phone, he'd just started to make dinner, and our interview was punctuated by the faint clang of kitchen implements. It was late—9 or 10 p.m.—but he'd recently finished a skills test for a new job (one of three) and couldn't talk at any other time. Even so, he's right to say he's lucky. He's about as lucky as anyone violently displaced from their home can be. His affiliation with the U.S. military allowed him to bypass many of the bureaucratic hurdles faced by refugees seeking resettlement. There are usually around 20 million refugees worldwide at any given time, according to the United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees (UNHCR)—less than one percent of whom are eligible for resettlement. Under ordinary circumstances—that is, not accounting for crises like the current war in Syria—the U.S. will take in half of those eligible. In most years, that's between sixty and seventy-five thousand people.

Except for special cases, like Ahmed's, these refugees are chosen by the UNHCR and then vetted by U.S. Citizenship and Immigration Services (USCIS), an arm of the Department of Homeland Security.

As soon as a refugee enters the

* "Ahmed" asked that his name be changed to preserve his anonymity.

U.S., her case is passed to the State Department's Bureau for Population, Refugee, and Migration (PRM). The PRM, along with the Office of Refugee Resettlement, works with nine non-governmental resettlement agencies to provide services for newly arrived refugees.

The Refugee Act of 1980 codified the voluntary agency system into law, but the history of resettlement in the U.S. is much older.

"The program began after World War II," explained William Haney, director of external relations for Church World Services (CWS), one of the nine resettlement agencies. "Things were done on a much more ad hoc basis—a church in New Haven or elsewhere would take in refugees, and they would live with host families and be sponsored by the church."

Like CWS, most of the national agencies were formed during or after World War II, though there are exceptions—the oldest, the Hebrew Immigrant Aid Society (HIAS) dates back to 1881, and the newest, the Ethiopian Community Development Council (ECDC), was founded in 1983. Though many of the same local chapters are in place today, the agencies have expanded and centralized their operations. The loose, organic networks of the 1930s and '40s now do most of their work through 350 local affiliates in communities across the country.

New Haven's local resettlement organization, Integrated Refugee and Immigrant Services (IRIS), is a subsidiary of two of the national agencies – CWS and the Episcopal Migration Ministries (EMM). It resettles about 230 refugees each year and maintains close contact with another 200. During a refugee's first few weeks, caseworkers provide housing, furniture, food, and clothes. They also coordinate programs to help refugees find employment, learn English, and access legal services.

All of this happens in a blocky, unprepossessing building on a sycamore-lined street a few blocks from East Rock Park. Its closest neighbors are an abandoned warehouse, a gas station, a handful of faux-Victori-



an and Cape Cod-style houses, and Wilbur Cross High School. In previous years, IRIS has settled refugee families nearby, but rising prices have made it increasingly difficult to find housing. Shops still have signs advertising halal meat and bodegas sell za'atar on pita, but a new family is more likely to find their first apartment in East Haven or Newhallville.

Culture and demographics are important factors to consider when deciding where to resettle new refugees, according to Will Kneeram, IRIS' Director of Education and Employment Services. The national agencies "distribute" families based on a number of different elements.

"If they have a U.S. tie—that's a friend or relative living in the country—that's our first priority," Kneeram told *The Politic*. "If not, they'll look to areas where there are existing populations from the same nationality, culture, or language group."

New Haven has a large population of immigrants from North Africa and the Middle East, especially Sudan, Congo, Eritrea, Iraq, and Afghanistan. A strong immigrant community can make it much easier for refugees to adjust to a new culture, which is why Arabic or Amharic speakers are more likely to be assigned to New Haven while Burmese or Bhutanese families might end up in Hartford. These groups often grow organically, as new immigrants join relatives already in the U.S. Others, like New Haven's Iraqi community, are the result of the refugee resettlement program. It's no accident that Ahmed ended up in this particular city, which has been a designated site for Iraqis since 2007.

Culture and demographics are important factors to consider when deciding where to resettle new refugees, according to Will Kneeram, IRIS' Director of Education and Employment Services.

Even with a community in place, it is difficult for refugees to adjust.

"Things like understanding cost of monthly rent and utilities, the process of getting kids registered for school, sending paperwork – it's a huge challenge," says Kneeram. Refugees must negotiate a system of unspoken legal, social, and cultural assumptions just to find employment, or send their children to school.

Like most of IRIS's clients, Ahmed initially had trouble finding a job in his field. He worked in retail for three years before being hired as an IT consultant for a small business. Now, he wants to bring his family to the U.S.

"I have a green card," he told *The Politic*, "but still, the process I have to go through is very, very complicated, even for my mother and father. I have to be a citizen to bring them, and I have to make a certain income, above $70,000 a year. And that's just for my parents. I also have two sisters and two brothers, and each of them has four or five kids."

Ahmed's relatives still live in Baghdad. He last saw them in May on a trip to renew his passport and birth certificate. Four months later, his frustration was still audible.

"I felt truly sorry for the people who were there," he said. "It's not only security issues. There are people who don't have services there – social services, living services, any type of services."

Although Ahmed receives legal aid from IRIS, he doesn't yet know when his family will be able to join him. Even after the legal challenges are cleared, they'll have to go through the same frustratingly opaque application process.

Of being vetted in Malaysia, Ahmed said, "When you ask any question—am I going to go there, or what's going on—nobody will answer you. Nobody tells you, O.K., you're going to the U.S. this time, this is how long it takes. You don't talk with anyone. You come for interviews and you leave, that's it."

Despite its omnipresent bureaucracy, Ahmed still prefers the U.S. to Baghdad or Malaysia.

"You never have to worry about people trying to kill you." He cleared his throat and paused before continuing. "Baghdad, I'm going to be honest with you—before 2003, it was a great

place to live. We never felt unsafe. People didn't have a lot of money, but still, it was safe to live. We didn't have any terrorists, really, before 2003. I know we had Saddam Hussein, and he was a bad guy, we hated him. But compared to that, the situation is worse. Before we had one bad guy, and now we have a thousand of them."

On a national level, the time lost because of bureaucracy is a major barrier to resettling more refugees in the U.S. Deborah Stein, the director of CWS, cited the vetting process as the first major obstacle to increasing quotas.

"We always want to make sure that every safety precaution is taken in terms of vetting refugees before they're allowed to travel to the U.S., but that takes a lot of time," she stressed. "In some cases, it's an unnecessary amount of time that could be decreased by better coordination between governmental agencies."

Haney had similar concerns about "the sheer size of the program and the bureaucratic hurdles." But recent events have left him cautiously optimistic.

"There's an opportunity now with the Syrian crisis to look at things in a different way than the U.S. has done, to look back earlier in our history," he explained. "We took in about 200,000 Vietnamese in some years during the '80s, and similar numbers from the Balkans in the '90s. They were handled differently. There was expedited processing, and refugees were taken out of danger immediately."

In both cases, the military airlifted refugees out of an ongoing conflict and brought them to military bases in the U.S., where they went through a much shorter vetting process before being resettled en masse. Between 1975 and 1994, 690,000 Vietnamese refugees were settled throughout the U.S. Southwest. Much of the political impetus for the program came from America's involvement in Vietnam. American politicians felt uniquely responsible for the crisis. In many ways, the situation is analogous to the modern Middle East.

Haney and Stein also agreed on the second major barrier to increasing resettlement quotas—political opinion. The President decides how many refugees the United States will accept annually. This year, it was 70,000. Next year, it will be 85,000, as part of a gradual increase to 100,000 by 2017. Many human rights groups and several of the major refugee resettlement organizations are pushing for the U.S. to accept 100,000 Syrians alone, in addition to the 100,000-refugee cap.

Increasing the cap is largely a political hurdle, Stein told me matter-of-factly.

"A lot of what makes things difficult is the acceptance of Americans to having more refugees in the United States. When politicians see there's public support for it, they're much more likely to support it themselves."

The Syrian crisis has pushed refugee policy into the public eye.

"Look at what happened after that absolutely heartbreaking photograph of that boy washing up on the shore," Stein said, referencing the recent photo of a drowned Syrian toddler lying alone on a Turkish beach. "That has absolutely galvanized public opinion all over the world. It's amazing it took something so extreme to grab people's attention when this war in Syria has been going on for years, and four million people have already been displaced. It's not like this crisis started with that picture…You can tell by the uptick in calls we've been getting."

According to Haney, the situation at CWS is similar.

"There's support on the ground in the U.S. to take as many refugees as possible from this crisis. And where there's a will, there's a way, in the end."

"Things like understanding cost of monthly rent and utilities, the process of getting kids registered for school, sending paperwork – it's a huge challenge"


I STAND WITH PLANNED PARENTHOOD®



PHOTO EDITED BY CERYS HOLSTEGE

This is What Planned Parenthood Looks Like

BY **LINA VOLIN**

A sea of pink flooded the corner of College and Chapel on the evening of September 29. Planned Parenthood volunteers passed out pink t-shirts branded with the organization's logo and loud, bright pink signs emblazoned with statements of support. The crowd, a mix of Yale students and other Connecticut residents, lined the sidewalk on all four corners of the intersection. Chants of "this is what Planned Parenthood looks like" and "hey-hey-ho-ho, patriarchy has got to go" drowned out the shouts of a small group of counter-protesters, who waved graphic signs and stood at the edge of the crowd of Planned Parenthood supporters. Dozens of cars passing through the intersection enthusiastically honked their support, eliciting fresh waves of cheers. In this manner, the group declared its support for Planned Parenthood on the organization's national Pink Out Day, celebrating the right to abortion established decades ago by the U.S. Supreme Court.

Fifty years ago, just blocks away from the site of September's demonstration, Connecticut residents embarked on another fight for reproductive rights. On November 1, 1961, Planned Parenthood opened a center in New Haven. Nine days later, New Haven police shut it down. Officers arrested two people: Estelle Griswold, executive director of the Planned Parenthood League of Connecticut, and Dr. C. Lee Buxton of Yale Medical School, a volunteer at the clinic. The court charged Griswold and Buxton with distributing birth control to married women, at the time an illegal practice in Connecticut. In 1965, the Supreme Court reviewed the case, and, fifty years later, *Griswold v. Connecticut* is remembered as the landmark ruling that first explicitly stated that the Constitution guarantees a right to privacy.

The right to privacy established under *Griswold* formed the legal basis for several subsequent cases involving reproductive rights. Chief among these is *Roe v. Wade*, decided in 1973, which declared that a woman has a right to an abortion in all states. Despite the forty-plus years since the *Roe* decision, the issue of reproductive rights—abortion in particular—has hardly diminished in importance. "[Reproductive rights] have become

the political and judicial litmus test for a lot of people," Caroline Chiappetti, president of Law Students for Reproductive Justice at Harvard Law School, told *The Politic*. The opposing viewpoints of the issue clash everywhere, from courtrooms and legislative chambers to snarky Tweets and impassioned Facebook posts.

Planned Parenthood, a national family planning and women's health services organization, is at the epicenter of the most recent controversy. Following the release of several undercover videos allegedly showing Planned Parenthood officials discussing the illegal sale of fetal tissue, calls to defund Planned Parenthood, and a subsequent defense of the organization, have swept Congress and social media. This is hardly a new situation for Planned Parenthood. It has been the target of repeated, concerted attacks by the anti-abortion opposition for years.

This particular controvesy began with the release of a video on July 28 by the Center for Medical Progress, a self-described group of citizen journalists. The first video, obtained by undercover activists using hidden cameras, included conversations with high-ranking Planned Parenthood officials on the topic of fetal tissue donation. The Center for Medical Progress accused Planned Parenthood of generating illegal profit from the sale of aborted fetuses.

In a statement released on the Planned Parenthood website, Eric Ferrero, its vice president of communications, addressed the financial aspect of fetal tissue donation as benefiting neither the patient nor the nonprofit.

"In some instances, actual costs, such as the cost to transport tissue to leading research centers, are reimbursed," he wrote in the statement.

The video and several similar videos that followed have been dismissed as heavily edited and creating a false impression of the fetal tissue donation program. While the use of fetal tissue for research is legal under federal law, the accusation that Planned Parenthood illegally profits from the donations led the House Judiciary Committee to launch an investigation. The first in a series of Congressional hearings entitled "Planned Parenthood Exposed: Examining the Horrific Abortion Practices at the Nation's Largest Abortion Provider" took place on September 9.

In a statement released prior to the hearing, House Judiciary Chairman Bob Goodlatte (R-VA) and Constitution and Civil Justice Subcommittee Chairman Trent Franks (R-AZ) wrote: "We are pleased to have the opportunity to question a panel of experts on this issue in order to ascertain how Planned Parenthood may have violated federal laws in the course of its alleged practices, and the atrocities associated with altering abortions in order to obtain the body parts of the fetuses."

Priscilla Smith, director of the Program for the Study of Reproductive Justice at Yale Law School's Information Society Project, joined three other experts in testifying at the hearing.

"The hearing was an anti-abortion hearing," she said in an interview with *The Politic*.

"They weren't investigating what was really going on with Planned Parenthood. They didn't call a Planned Parenthood witness, they didn't call the people who had examined the tapes… they didn't even ask for the full tapes."

According to Smith, several lawmakers running the hearing seemed to harbor misconceptions about Planned Parenthood.

"The biggest misconception was that no one who goes to Planned Parenthood is a parent. They thought by definition if you went to Planned Parenthood you were not a parent," she said. "Sixty percent of women who get abortions are already parents."

Congress' investigation into Planned Parenthood continued with testimony by the organization's president, Cecile Richards, on September 29. In her remarks, she addressed the edited nature of the videos.

"The outrageous accusations leveled against Planned Parenthood based on heavily doctored videos are offensive and categorically untrue," she said during her testimony.

The hearing came as Republicans doubled down on efforts to introduce legislation that imposes further limits on abortions, such as the Pain-Capable Unborn Child Protection Act, which passed the House of Representatives last May. The Act calls for a federal ban on abortions starting at week 20 of a pregnancy, with exceptions for endangerment of the mother's life, rape, or incest. These exceptions are also subject to new restrictions; the Act requires women to report rape to law enforcement before they can get an abortion, a requirement that deviates from current policy.

Political opponents are also attacking Planned Parenthood's funding. Currently, Planned Parenthood receives government funding through two sources: the

Where government funding goes

STI treatment and testing

In 2013, Planned Parenthood provided nearly 4.5 million tests and treatments for STIs

Contraceptives

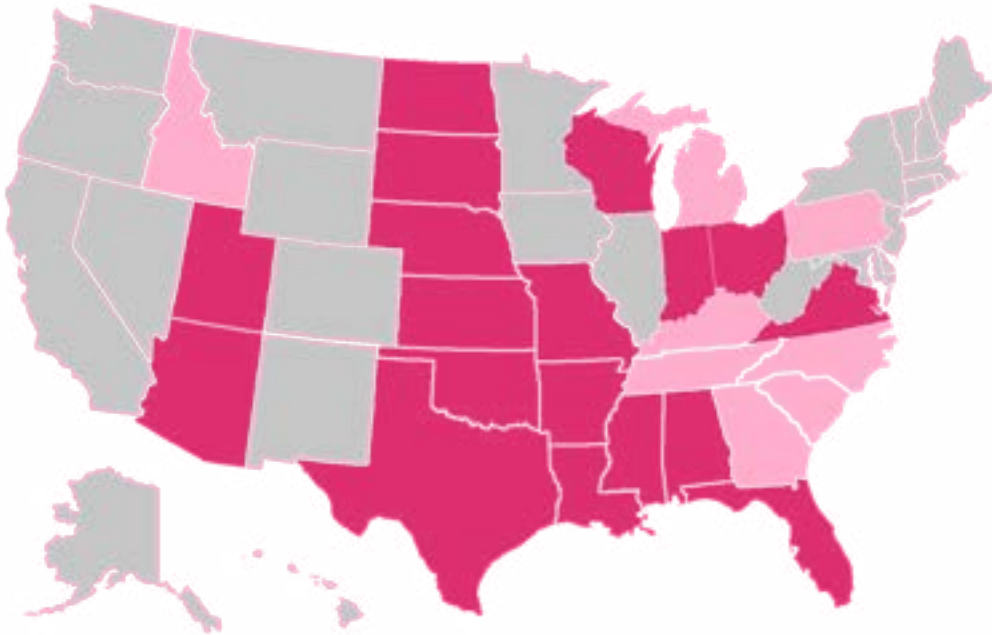
In 2013, Planned Parenthood provided nearly 3.56 million contraceptive-related services.

Pregnancy tests and prenatal care

In 2013, Planned Parenthood provided nearly 1.1 million pregnancy tests and prenatal services

Cancer screenings

In 2013, Planned Parenthood provided nearly 1 million cancer screenings



HOSTILE

EXTREMELY HOSTILE

According to the Guttmacher Institute, as of 2014, 27 states are hostile to abortion, and 18 of those are extremely hostile. Extremely hostile states have 6-10 restrictions on abortion, while hostile states have 4-5 restrictions.

Title X Family Planning program and Medicaid. By statute, no funds received via Title X grants may be used to perform abortions. Medicaid funds may be used in abortion procedures only in cases involving the aforementioned exceptions: endangerment of the mother's life, rape, or incest. These exceptions are dealt with on a state-by-state basis. This means that the funding Planned Parenthood receives from the federal government goes toward women's health services which, in 2013, included 4.5 million tests and treatment for STIs, 3.6 million contraception related services, 1.1 million pregnancy tests and prenatal services, and nearly 1 million cancer screenings. In other words, no federal dollars are going toward abortions that fall outside of the exempted situations.

Planned Parenthood's role as the biggest women's health services provider for low-income women prompted a spirited defense from Democrats in Congress. Senator Elizabeth Warren (D-MA) unequivocally stated that she stood with Planned Parenthood.

"The Republican vote to defund Planned Parenthood is just one more piece of a deliberate, methodical, orchestrated, right-wing attack on women's rights," she said in a speech delivered to Congress on August 3.

Politicians who oppose defunding Planned Parenthood reflect the opinion of most of the country. A Wall Street Journal/NBC News poll released September 28 indicated that six in ten Americans oppose defunding the nonprofit.

The strategy to defund Planned Parenthood temporarily stalled on September 30, when Congress passed a budget that included funding for the organization. This budget is set to fund the government through December 11, after which several conservative congressmen plan to raise the issue of Planned Parenthood funding again.

One such Sentator is Ted Cruz (R-TX), who has openly supported blocking Planned Parenthood's funding to the point of a government shutdown. He reiterated this sentiment in the first GOP debate. During the debate, Cruz called for Republicans to stand by their principles in the fight to defund Planned Parenthood.

"We shouldn't be sending $500 million of taxpayer money to funding an ongoing criminal enterprise," he said.

The subject of women's health services and of Planned Parenthood specifically has been a popular one in coverage of the 2016 election. Candidate Carly Fiorina referenced the Center for Medical Progress videos in the debate. She described a disturbing image of an aborted fetus kicking its legs on a table while medical practitioners discussed prolonging its life to harvest organs. This image was roundly discredited by fact-checkers and multiple media outlets, who reported that it never appeared in any of the released videos. In another episode featuring a presidential candidate, former governor of Florida Jeb Bush came under fire for saying, "I'm not sure we need half a billion dollars in funding for women's health programs." He later admitted that he misspoke and instead meant to refer solely to federal funding for Planned Parenthood.

On the other side of the debate, Democratic presidential candidates have reiterated their support for Planned Parenthood.

"I'm proud to stand with Planned Parenthood. I'll never stop fighting to protect the ability and right of every woman in this country said former Secretary of State Hillary

Clinton in a video released on August 3.

In a similar vein, Senator Bernie Sanders conveyed his support for Planned Parenthood in an interview with Univision's Jorge Ramos.

"I think a lot of this attack, to be honest with you, comes from people who simply do not believe that a woman should have a right to control her own body," he said.

These statements from candidates of both parties indicate the large role reproductive rights will play in national elections.

"[The debate over abortion] has often been a part of politics and elections, and I see no reason why 2016 will be any different," Brigitte Amiri, a Senior Staff Attorney at the American Civil Liberties Union's (ACLU) Reproductive Freedom Project, told *The Politic*. "Perhaps it will create an opportunity for public conversation on the issue, for people to tell their elected officials and their soon-to-be elected officials how important this issue is to them."

Beyond the immediacy of this most recent controversy and its political backlash lies the perilous state of reproductive rights in the U.S. *Roe* was hardly the final word on abortion. Since that ruling, states have passed laws restricting abortion, many of which have been declared constitutional in subsequent court cases. Amiri, as a litigator for the ACLU, fights cases around the country that restrict access to abortion and contraception. In her thirteen years in reproductive rights law, she has never been busier.

"I am confident in saying that we are under siege," she said. "We're in dire straits on the state of reproductive rights."

She identified the ACLU Reproductive Freedom Project's primary goal as keeping clinic doors open. But doing so has become difficult in recent years, as states have codified abortion restrictions into law.

The Guttmacher Institute reported that 267 abortion restrictions have been implemented in 31 states since 2011. Restrictions include mandates that clinics conform to hospital-like physical standards, orders most are unable to comply with. These restrictions are called "TRAP" (Targeted Regulation of Abortion Providers) laws—they require clinics that offer abortion services to comply with requirements that are more onerous than those demanded of other medical practices. These requirements can often be too costly for existing facilities to follow, causing abortion clinics to close.

"They are shutting down clinics more successfully than they have been able to in the past," said Smith, director of Yale Law School's Reproductive Justice program. "There are large parts of Texas where you can't find an abortion provider for 500 miles. Mississippi has one abortion clinic left."

The last clinic in Mississippi was threatened with closure in 2012 when the state legislature purposefully introduced unrealistic admitting privilege requirements. Advocates challenged the law and now the case, *Currier v. Jackson Women's Health Organization*, is pending review by the Supreme Court.

"[*Currier*] is just a stark highlight of what happens when restrictions upon restrictions get passed in a particular state," said Amiri, the ACLU lawyer. "Mississippi dwindled to just one, and the legislature in Mississippi was determined to close that clinic."

Connecticut, in comparison to many other states, has fewer abortion restrictions and far greater accessibility to abortion services, with 41 abortion providers in 2011. Providers in New Haven include Planned Parenthood and Yale Family Planning. Organizations providing women's health services abound, with several near Yale.

The Planned Parenthood clinic, however, remains the primary distributor of health services for low-income women in the area. The rally on September 29th, which mirrored public demonstrations in cities and on college campuses across the country, emphasized the pivotal role Planned Parenthood plays in the community. Despite the negative politics and intense debate, Planned Parenthood is gradually rising above the controversy, just as it has so many times before. to make her own health decisions,"

"They are shutting down clinics more successfully than they have been able to in the past. There are large parts of Texas where you can't find an abortion provider for 500 miles. Mississippi has one abortion clinic left."

"I see WHO's role as being the moral voice and the technical leader in improving health of the people of the world, ready and able to give advice on the key issues that can unleash development and alleviate suffering." (1998)

An interview with

Gro Harlem Brundtland

Former Prime Minister of Norway

In your acceptance speech from 1998, you announced a mission for the World Health Organization. Your term ended in 2003, 12 years ago. Looking back at the past 17 years, what do you think were the greatest accomplishments of the WHO? Has it fulfilled the mission you hoped?

Well, at that time, when I said that, I knew that we needed to reform the WHO to improve its efficiency. So I spent the first couple of years changing the system and improving the way we work, both internally and with regard to reforms on using our resources better, but also in convincing governments about the importance of health on the global political agenda, not just as a specialist field of health.

I think we can say we achieved this in these first years and that was one reason why we got the Tobacco Convention signed after five years, which is unusual. It's the first international health agreement. The fact that it was done in five years illustrates the status that we were able to achieve. It meant that the American health minister could go to President Bush and ask him to support him in signing the agreement, although there was a lot of opposition in the US. I think I had used an argument to the American ambassador that why would the Bush administration not want to sign an important health agreement when they recently had withdrawn the signature that Bill Clinton had gave to the Kyoto protocol in 1977? It just kind of added to the picture that the US was not collaborative with the rest of the world. Then of course we had the SARS situation in the 2000s, the same year, when these tobacco discussions were being finalized, and the world got alerted to the importance of the global health institution.

What are flaws that the WHO still has to deal with?

Is the level of attention to global health issues [the same] as [it was] in 2003? That is not obvious because we now have the Ebola crisis and the WHO has not been so much in the lead as it should have been in that crisis. I think the decentralization is one reason [for this] because you have regional health offices, and if the principal has let the regions lead their legions and the center becomes less effective, I don't think this is the right way. It has kind of decentralized authority. The African region was dealing with the Ebola crisis for too long alone.

How did you get involved with The Elders? What the operations and aims of the organization are today?

The Elders is an international NGO of public figures noted as elder statesmen, peace activists, and human rights advocates, who were brought together by Nelson Mandela in 2007. They describe themselves as "independent global leaders working together for peace and human rights".

[We've been working on] an unsolved conflict in Europe, in Cyprus, where you have the aftermath of a war between Turkey and Greece going back to the 1970s. And after 40 years you still have barbed wire and separated communities with military attendants on both sides. So we thought it must be possible to find a solution in Cypress. But I have to say it turned out to be very difficult. It was not just getting the attention of the leaders on both sides, and speaking with the Turks and the Greeks. The political dynamics of elections happening in both communities led to peace accords not becoming popular enough that those leaders were able to shake hands. We had to make the conclusion that for the time being it's not possible to get those parties into a constructive dialogue.

From the beginning we decided a general issue globally is discrimination against women worldwide. And President Carter was very adamant about this; he has been fighting in his church, in America, to get equal treatment of women, and he hasn't succeeded. In the end he had to leave his church. Because even with his background and his strong personality, he could not convince the congregation there to start treating the women and men equally as servants to the church in different positions.

So we took this on from the

religious perspective. We found out that child marriage is a major problem. Now it is more on people's' minds then it was because we started raising that issue in 2009 and 2010. Gradually, we created an alliance against child marriage after having worked with small NGOs who were dealing with it, and met with leaders in Africa, Ethiopia, India, and so on about it. Now, in the context of the U.N. post-2015, child marriage is part of what's mentioned. It never would have been if we hadn't started speaking out.

What is the future of The Elders?

I think it is a group that can help bring people together who are apart, because sometimes national interests and historical considerations and things that have happened lead to stalemate and the issue is dropped. But if new people come in who are independent and who have not been engaged in things that have happened before, you can help revitalize dialogue. In that context, I think we can help.

What is it like to be a symbol of the fight for women's rights, world peace, and environmental protection for so many women and men?

Well, I don't know how it feels, it just happens to be what I have done. The pieces are logically merged together in my mind. First, as a young person, I realized that there is discrimination against women. So, I had the determination that I had to work to improve the condition for girls and women, in my country and internationally as I started to realize that it is not only true in my country, [but] even more so in other places.

[As prime minister I worked on] human rights for women and then environmental concerns, which means sustainable development, climate issues and of course trying to get nonproliferation and nuclear disarmament. It meant that my agenda became very broad.

Do you remember a moment or an episode when you clearly felt like you made an impact?

You can take moments like when I announced a new Norwegian government with close to an equal number of men and women. It is a radical move that people have never seen before. You realize that you are making an impact. First of all, you do the right thing for the country, but you also know that you symbolize something that is future-oriented and shows a way forward.

This is just one example of decisions where you are aware that it can mean something to many people in the long term. I understand how young people can get disillusioned about politics because of the domination of money on the American continent. The democratic assessment of politics gets lost in this jungle of money and pressure groups, and buying politicians by giving them funding.

For us, as Europeans and certainly for me as a Norwegian, this is completely unheard of. I never asked for funding for anything for myself. Ever. I didn't have to. We don't have political advertisements; you cannot pay for time on television. So the whole thing becomes so different, and then you can work to convince people about issues. You cannot pay your time and pay your way. It's the argument or the passion which you decide to express yourself which counts, not money.

What made you decide to enter the realm of politics?

Here, you see, I have a very special story. When I was thirty five, I was in the public health arena, but I was doing research on child development issues. One day I was called to the Prime Minister's office and asked to enter the government, in the middle of my doctoral dissertation work. I never made a plan to enter into politics. I was picked because they wanted a woman minister. A woman had died that summer from cancer, and that August the prime minister was looking for a successor. So I was picked. But within a few months I was fully aware of how much more influence I [had] as minister of environment than I had before as a public health expert. From then on, I stayed in the political arena, and it was never an alternative to seek to leave it because I was fed up or something. I knew that here is where you can have the most influence and do the most good, whether nationally or internationally. As an environment minister, you travel to international meetings about international environmental problems, pollution, water shortages, all of it. I became deputy leader of the liberal party very quickly after I became minister. I was taken to the party leadership, which again was a commitment. You could not say yes to do that and then leave after a few years. Then I became leader [of the party] and Prime Minister.

What is your advice for students who are thinking about a career in politics?

I was at Stanford last year for two months, and many students there asked me the question that you ask now. What advice would you give me for my career? Find out what makes you tick, where is it that you really enjoy working. I am not the right person to ask if you are a cold-blooded kind of strategist, what career step should you make to make a lot of money. Now, that's not what you asked, of course. But what I am saying is there are so many ways to pursue those issues, and the choice itself is not the essential thing. It is that you go somewhere where you think you can make a difference and where you can work with others to make things happen, to inspire others and to combine forces to make good things happen. Then you can end up anywhere. The important thing is to feel that you can contribute, because that makes you [live] a meaningful life with others.

Is Experience Payment Enough?

BY **DECLAN KUNKEL**

Unpaid Internships Present an Ethical Dilemma

It's one o'clock in the morning, and I'm hanging upside-down from a piece of aluminum trussing hung forty five feet above the stage. In front of me is a spotlight, a four hundred pound steel canister that I have to lower to the ground by hand before I can leave for the night. It has been ten hours since my last meal break and a solid fifteen since I reported for work this morning. I'm dead tired and just about everyone around me is, too.

It is at this moment that I again regret applying for an internship with "real-world entertainment experience"—their words, not mine. These hours of unpaid labor demonstrate the true nature of the modern internship. It isn't the company providing an opportunity to learn a craft; it is the company exploiting the labor of the desperate. Such unpaid internships often boast that interns gain experience working alongside leading professionals. This statement, at first glance unobjectionable, masks an unjust truth: interns often do the work of professionals, but they receive little to no compensation.

Lately this issue has featured prominently in national and international news. This past summer, the media turned its eye to David Hyde, a 22-year-old United Nations intern based in Geneva, Switzerland. The Tribune de Genève reported that Hyde was living in a tent while attempting to complete his internship at the United Nations, because he could not afford housing in the expensive real estate market of Geneva. Hyde had prior knowledge of the expense and money required to complete such an internship, but he couldn't give up the opporunity.

He admitted to the *Tribune*, "I have always wanted to pursue a career in the international field, and to do so it seemed that an internship was necessary, or at least highly desirable. At the same time, I strongly believed that unpaid internships are unjust because they further perpetuate inequality."

Hyde resigned from his internship two days after the news of his circumstances broke of his circumstances. The hypocrisy seemed so clear. The United Nations, dedicated to human rights and fighting against inequality, maintains an internship policy that seems to clearly contradict the values it claims to support throughout the world. Hyde argues that it is inherently wrong for an organization to act as the United Nations did—championing social justice and wage equality while still relying on unpaid labor.

Hyde's case may seem like an anomaly—he willingly camped outside, so he understood the circumstances of his unpaid internship—but it sheds light on a more difficult question: Are unpaid internships ethical?

There is little consensus on this matter. Many argue that interns benefit exclusively through experience. To me, however, it seems wrong for an intern to relocate for an unpaid

position. There have been several lawsuits in the past two years surrounding this very issue. The most publicized lawsuit concerning the legality of unpaid internships surrounded the production of the 2010 Oscar-winning movie *Black Swan*. The case's plaintiffs were Fox Searchlight interns Eric Glatt and Alexander Footman, neither of whom received compensation for their work as production interns on the feature film. Glatt and Footman alleged that they were classified as employees under the Fair Labor Standards Act and should have been entitled to compensation for their duties as members of the *Black Swan* production staff. They filed a lawsuit, which then became a nationwide class action case that represented all Fox Searchlight interns. A district court, presided over by judge William Paley III, favored Glatt and Footman. The court decided that because the interns contributed meaningful work to the film, they should be compensated per hour of work at minimum wage.

"I strongly believed that unpaid internships are unjust because they further perpetuate inequality"

This decision was recently overturned by the 2nd Circuit Court of Appeals. Though siding with Fox Searchlight, the court stated that the entire issue surrounding interns stems from whether interns or the company benefit from an internship. If the company benefits, then the intern must be paid. The ruling essentially kicked the case back to the lower court to decide, but it still left many questions unanswered. The ruling against Glatt and Footman touched on the fact that unpaid internships are legal if interns can receive school credit through the internship because it is tied to their coursework. Interns are expected to be trained in conjunction with what they learn at their universities. This could count as a form of compensation.

Rachel Bien, a partner at Outten and Golden, the leading class-action law firm and counsel for Glatt and Footman throughout their legal proceedings, discussed her work on the case with *The Politic*. Bien argued that the fluid definition of internships makes it particularly hard to state exactly what the legal definition is. According to Bien, the legal trouble surrounding unpaid internships stems from the vague wording of the Fair Labor Standards Act. When the legislation was created, it sought to define an employee in broad enough terms that all laborers would be included. Essentially, when the law was created, the federal government intended that it protect all workers, which at the time included diverse groups like children and day laborers. To ensure that everyone was covered, the law has no statement about internships.

This vague definition has caused a major controversy: what defines the "benefits" of a worker's labor? If the company benefits more from the intern's work than the intern gains in experience, it seems that the intern should be paid. If the intern benefits more from the experience than the company benefits from having him, then the intern should not be paid. The Second Circuit's ruling touches on how hard this is to calculate, saying that there are certain "tangible and intangible benefits" of an internship that must be considered.

However, it is not as if paid interns earn a large amount of money. They typically are paid minimum wage or a low, fixed amount for an entire semester or summer.

Bien added, "There are aspects of the Second Circuit's ruling that make [the ruling] problematic for future lawsuits." In particular, the cost of a lawsuit of this nature far exceeds the proceeds, which are usually reclaimed minimum-wage hourly paychecks. As a class action lawsuit can take hundreds to thousands of hours to prepare, it simply is not in an attorney's interest to take one on, especially

since the cases usually involve such a small sum. This leaves unpaid interns caught in the middle of corporate decision-making—they often cannot pursue legal action because of the high cost, and thus they receive no compensation.

Bien added that if an intern feels as if he or she is trapped in an internship, he or she should contact an attorney who can help without involving the courts. For example, many lawyers will simply contact the company to act as mediators between the company and the interns. This allows the company to avoid a very public lawsuit and lets the intern avoid incurring massive court debt.

Jeanine Dames, associate dean of Yale College and the director of the Office of Career Strategy, also highlighted the complicated nature of the Fair Labor Standards Act in an interview with *The Politic*. Both she and Brian Frenette, associate director of the Yale Office of Career Strategy, highlighted the fundamental differences between unpaid internships in the non-profit and governmental sector versus unpaid internships in the for-profit sector. The nonprofit and government sector, Dames said, is "excused from paying interns" under the Fair Labor Standards Act.

This exemption still raises ethical issues. Many interns working in nonprofit and government jobs (like David Hyde at the U.N.) work long hours at jobs that they cannot afford, hoping that one day this work will lead to better job prospects. This in itself can be an issue. More affluent students often have the financial advantage of not needing to earn an income over the summer, while lower income students may rely heavily on the summer to generate income.

Frenette stated that the fact that nonprofit internships usually don't pay "predisposes a particular type of student to those activities—those who can afford it on their own," putting low income students at an inherent disadvantage.

Santosh Murugan, the co-founder and chief executive officer of Bright Future for the Blind, an international nonprofit that provides education to the blind in India, said in an interview with *The Politic* that an internship is effectively a "contract between the employee and the intern."

"The employer provides valuable experience and connections for the employee. In turn, the intern has a responsibility to use his or her skills to add value to the company," he said.

He went on to say that the essential basis of an internship is to gain "non-monetary compensation," especially experience, which has a "more long-term value." Essentially, Murugan argued that internships are fluid and that the ethics of an unpaid internship must be judged on a case-by-case basis.

On one hand, interns gain knowledge from an internship, yet at the same time, they contribute very meaningful work to the corporation. Internships fill a valuable spot in the madness of a student's search for work, but they pose many ethical dilemmas. It is not possible to say with ease which internships are and are not legal. They are as diverse and unique as the people working with them. This search for the definition of a legal internship began with the hope of discovering a straight, hard, and fast rule, but unfortunately, none exists.

If these discussions with Bien, Frenette, Dames, and Murugan have led to any realization, it is this: In order to evaluate if interns should be paid, we must ask if interns are gaining more than the company? If they are, then many contend that their experience is payment enough. If not, then interns should be paid.

My unpaid internship in entertainment did provide me with the experience I needed to get a full-time job, which paid well and which I greatly enjoyed. But it is hard for me to say whether it was worth the 100-hour weeks and sleepless nights spent lowering spotlights to the ground.





WINCHESTER RECLAIMED —

From

GUN FACTORY

to

LUXURY LOFTS

By Finnegan Schick

PAST INGALLS RINK UP WINCHESTER AVENUE, WHERE PLYWOOD BOARDS FILL WINDOWS AND BROKEN BOTTLES SIT IN POTHOLES, SPRAWLS NEWHALLVILLE,

a predominantly black neighborhood with more ivy on its walls than Yale. On the corner of Winchester, Munson, and Henry is a former gun factory, the Winchester Repeating Arms Company. There are many sides to Winchester, and everyone tells a different story about its rise and fall.

Once home to a multi-million dollar arms manufacturer, the factory complex today is split into two courtyards. The street-facing courtyard has recently been renovated. Clean brick walls and dark-paned windows ensconce a brand-new apartment complex. The rear courtyard, untouched since the factory closed in 2006, is hidden from street view—its abandoned spaces covered by crabgrass, grime, and graffiti. To get inside the ruins of the old courtyard you must squeeze through a two-foot gap in a chain-link fence. Swallows nest in the rusted pipes and mosquitoes breed in pools of stagnant water. It's desolate, but full of life.

Back in the renovated courtyard, saplings border a concrete quad near a large electrical generator. One afternoon this summer, two dozen people gathered here for the grand opening of the 160 apartments of Winchester Lofts. Men sporting ties and tailored suits and women clad in black dresses came to watch the ribbon cutting ceremony, impervious to the punishing 90 degree heat of the cloudless day.

Bruce Alexander '65, Yale's Vice President for New Haven and State Affairs, comes to the podium.

"New Haven is a city on the move," he said.

Alexander has reason to celebrate. Since 1983, the city and Yale have been partners in a renovation project to revitalize the beleaguered Newhallville neighborhood. These new apartments, built by Forest City Real Estate, sit in the middle of Science Park, an 80-acre plot of industrial wasteland that the Science Park Development Corporation has transformed into a technology enclave. Forest City builds a wide range of office spaces and apartments in large cities across the country.

A younger man stepped up to speak. He stretched out his arm, fingers spread toward the far wall of the courtyard.

"They don't make buildings like this anymore," the man said.

This man was Tim Sullivan, a former Barclays investment banker turned Deputy Commissioner for the Connecticut Department of Economic and Community Development. Sullivan thanked Yale, the architects, the developer, the city, and the state for the new apartments.

Sullivan closed with a promise: "To honor the past and keep it with us as we move forward."

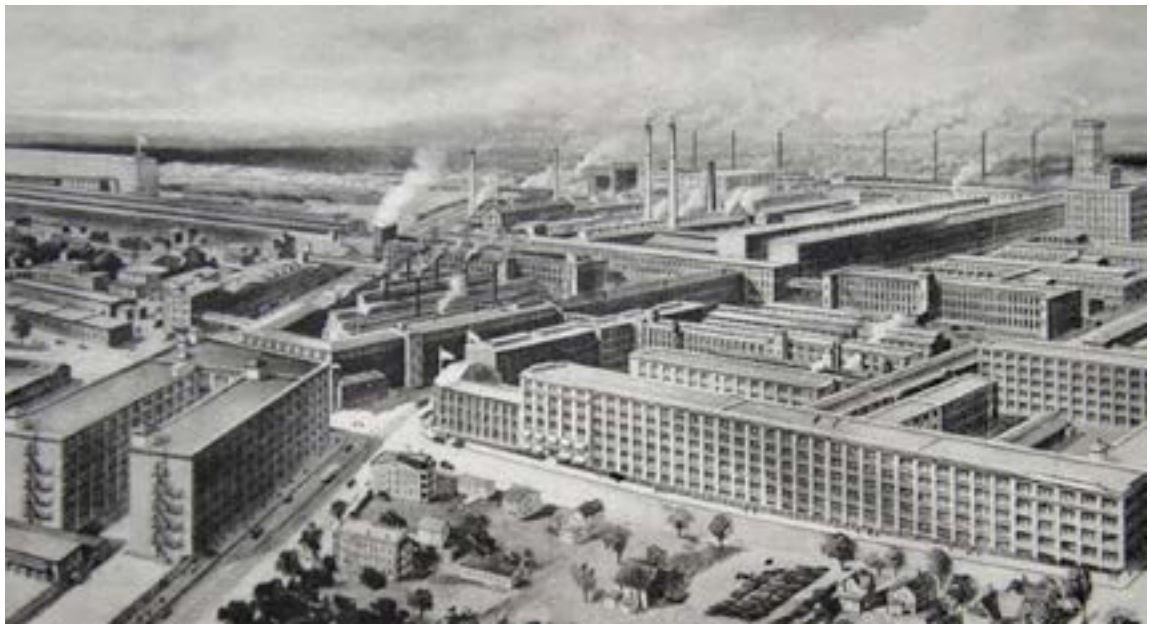
Winchester Lofts, 700,000 square feet of apartment in a factory setting, claims to be the "intersection of past and present." Built with "genuine craft," to quote its brochure, for young professionals looking for "the feeling of authenticity," Winchester Lofts offers an "artisanal" living experience. "The aged factory," reads a plaque in the lobby, is "rich with history, texture, architectural craft, and stories untold."

But to say that the new lofts preserve or embody the building's industrial past is a revisionist history. The spirit of the old factory and the new lofts are as different as leather and lace, and the machinists who made guns here have been replaced by plush rugs and matching faux-leather furniture. The new apartments embody a deeply stratified class system in America, and in New Haven, that is evident by walking a few blocks in any direction. The lofts are pricing out Newhallville residents. Yet most developers and historians cringe at the use of "gentrification" to describe how this neighborhood is changing. This presents a challenge in definition. What exactly happened at Winchester? Will the new lofts change the neighborhood for the better, or for the worse? Gentrification may be the future of the American city. But its cost may be the erasure of history.

The project to turn an old gun factory into upscale apartments started in 2008, but the story of Winchester began in 1855.

BY THE MIDDLE OF THE NINETEENTH century, New Haven already produced many of the nation's carriages and clocks—and soon it would become the gun capital of the world.

In 1855, inventors Horace Smith and Daniel B. Wesson moved their fledgling firearms factory to New Haven. The Volcanic Repeating Arms Company set up shop on the corner of Orange and Grove Street and employed fewer than 50 people during its first year. Despite considerable investment by 33 of New Haven's wealthiest businessmen, the Volcanic rifle was a failure, and within two years, the company began failing financially. Oliver Fischer Winchester, a beefy man who wore large black coats and cowboy hats, bought the company's assets and changed its name to the New Haven Repeating Arms Company.





Winchester, a successful clothing manufacturer, saw promise in a young firearm designer named Benjamin Tyler Henry. Winchester hired Henry as the factory's superintendent, and within three years the company had built a larger factory across the train tracks on Artizan Street and had a patent on a new .44 caliber rifle.

Nicknamed the "Henry," the new gun was a huge success. With the start of the Civil War in 1861, the gun market exploded. Although the Henry rifle was designed for sport, not combat, Union soldiers preferred this gun to those made by the Spencer Company—the lever-action design allowed for faster shooting, and the Henry had greater firepower.

The Henry helped the North win the Civil War, and after the war it would help the United States win the Western frontier. The Henry was redesigned in 1866 as the "Winchester 66" and became the gun of choice for buffalo hunters, pioneers, and sheriffs across the expanding frontier. Both Apache leader Geronimo and President Theodore Roosevelt carried models of the Winchester 66. Even John Wayne used a Winchester.

Through the rest of the nineteenth century, Winchester expanded. In 1869, it bought out the Spencer Company, Winchester's only large competitor. When Winchester received a bid from rifle contractors during World War I, it managed the near-impossible task of building a factory overnight. Most of the factory near Newhallville was built in less than a year, covering 82 acres and employing 16,000 people.

After the war, Winchester continued to grow, becoming the primary supplier for a growing American gun culture. By 1917 the company had produced over six million guns and rifles. An annual report to the company's stockholders from that year states that shooting licenses in the U.S. had increased to five million. Winchester documented that over 1,000 new gun clubs were founded, and high schools in dozens of states held courses in marksmanship.

"An important development in the arms and ammunition business has taken place," reads the stockholder report. "Thousands of new shooters are taking up this popular sport. Thousands of those who formerly used guns are again turning to their favorite pastime." The market for guns shifted from military to sport, and Winchester responded.

Guns were not just recreational. Shooting became a tool for teaching maturity and morality. Fathers were encouraged to take their boys hunting. After all, Winchester marketed its .22 caliber rifle as "your chance to make a pal of your son."

The American public had fallen in love with the gun. The covers of the *Winchester Record*, a monthly magazine circulated among company workers, evolved during the post-war years. After 1918, the magazine cover traded images of American soldiers for pictures of families hunting together. Industry and manufacturing promised a bright future for the working classes who ran the factories and ensured a recreational lifestyle for the leisure class. The Winchester factory had become its own city within New Haven. It employed 50 security guards, an emergency hospital staff of 17, and even had its own marching band.

Cities change, and the Winchester Factory set New Haven's course time and again. Across America the cost of skilled labor rose through the 1950s and 1960s, forcing companies to cut costs any way they could. Winchester guns were well-made, but many of the parts were also hand-made. To stay afloat, in 1964, Winchester replaced its older guns with a new line of cheaper models. The quality of the weapons decreased, and with it, Winchester's sales.

In 2006, after a century of falling in and out of bankruptcy, Winchester laid off the 186 remaining employees, and shortly thereafter announced that it would not reopen the New Haven factory. The license to make Winchester rifles was sold to Browning Firearms, which operates out of Utah. You can still buy a new Winchester rifle (most cost around $1,300), but it will no longer come from New Haven.

Because Winchester was far from self-sufficient, its departure weakened other industries. A network of New Haven factories supplied each other with materials.

"The wood came from one place, the gunpowder was made somewhere else," New Haven historian Rob Greenberg said. "As different businesses went out, it was a telltale sign that the industrial age was coming to an end."

When Craig Gauthier worked at Winchester, from 1973 to 1996, the factory was only one of many local industries.

Shooting became a tool for teaching maturity and morality. Fathers were encouraged to take their boys hunting. After all, Winchester marketed its .22 caliber rifle as "your chance to make a pal of your son."

Down Winchester Avenue was the G&O Radiator plant, and a brass mill employed around 600 people two blocks away.

"Along Winchester Avenue at that time you had all kinds of auto parts stores, small mom and pop stores, restaurants, and soul food," Gauthier said of Newhallville in the 1970s. "You had a pretty thriving community."

But relations between the community and the factory deteriorated in 1979 when the Winchester Machinists Union went on strike to prevent cuts to wages and benefits.

"With the 1979 strike you see the decline of Winchester and the city's manufacturing days," he said. "It was a turning point in terms of labor's influence and labor's ability to make a difference."

The size of the strike, and its impact on Winchester's production costs, made Winchester rethink its presence in New Haven. The company began to downsize the New Haven factory, and the number of employees at Winchester fell from 2,300 to 800 in the few years following the strike. And when the nearby brass mill closed, the G&O factory followed suit, putting hundreds more out of work.

"You could literally see the mom and pop stores closing, the restaurants closing," Gauthier said.

Winchester could no longer afford to stay in New Haven, and the community that relied on its jobs was coming apart at the seams.

"A lot of those people who lived in the Newhallville area worked at Winchester or with G&O," he said, adding that when they were laid off, many took to the streets. "People turned to alcohol and drugs to deal with the situation. The community really suffered a real downturn."

Crack cocaine became popular in Newhallville, and soon unemployment and crime rose throughout the city.

Yale School of Management Professor Douglas Rae is author of the book City: *Urbanism and Its End*, a portrait of New Haven and of urban decline. For Rae, the era of New Haven as a post-industrial wasteland is ending.

"This is the fifth scene of the third act," he said. "De-gentrification has been the big story for a very long time."

For seven years the factory sat vacant. Then came the new lofts. Forest City spent $10.6 million on the lofts, also taking out a $23 million bank loan to fund the first phase's $59.26 million price tag. They broke ground in September 2013, replacing 40,000 square feet of wood decking and remaking the guts of the old factory. Toxic materials like asbestos and lead were removed. It wasn't cheap to build, and it's not cheap to live in, either. A studio apartment here costs $1,300 a month, but renters can pay up to $3,000 a month for a two-bedroom. The lofts boast amenities like a gymnasium, yoga and kickboxing rooms, and a dog-washing station.

But Rae said the lofts are not a sign of gentrification at all. "I wouldn't even pull the word out of the dictionary," he said.

Winchester Lofts might be more expensive than other homes in the area, but Rae said New Haven still has plenty of low-end real estate to spare. This sounds like a win-win for the neighborhood, but Rae said the new lofts are not guaranteed to succeed.

"[The project], as capital investments in real estate go, is pretty risky," Rae said. The city's residential market is saturated. "If you were doing real estate finance 101, this would be somewhere at the back of the book as an unusual strategy," he added.

Yale has been the largest developer of Science Park, moving 800 of its employees here and building a parking garage. Higher One, a financial services company, also moved into a section of the Winchester factory in March 2012. The company was founded by three Yale graduates, and has been called "New Haven's Google" by local newspapers.

Because the building is of historical significance (the district is listed on the National Register of Historic Places) the lofts were partially paid for with national and state tax credits amounting to $19.6 million. But these tax credits put limitations on what Forest City could build. For example, brick walls had to stay exposed and wooden support beams had to be kept in the roof. The windows were designed to replicate the original factory windows. Before construction could begin, the blueprints had to be approved by a state historic preservation officer and a National Parks Service reviewer.

The lofts claim to be more than just a new apartment building. They "reveal beauty amidst [the factory's] hidden chambers." A Boston-based photographer captured images of the decrepit factory that hang in the hallways. A local artist made woodcarvings of old wood beams that now stand in the lobby. An old factory door is now a conference table, and Winchester Rifle ads are memorialized as posters throughout the lofts.

Abe Naparstek is the senior vice-president of Forest City. The nearby Newhallville community is glad to see lights back on in a long-vacant building, but many residents are concerned the city may be passing them by. Although Forest City ensured 25 percent of the construction workers were minorities and that 25 percent were New Haven residents, most of the apartments' residents will have higher incomes. 80 percent of the lofts rent at market rates; the remaining 20 percent are for middle and low-income people.

Winchester Lofts will soon expand to the upper courtyard of the old factory. The next phase is about halfway complete and will bring 200 additional apartments to the 160 already in the south courtyard. The 40,000 additional square feet would include a small park exclusively for residents, an outdoor WiFi lounge, a bocce court, a swimming pool, and an outdoor grilling kitchen. Naparstek expects a nearby retail space to fill with shops once more people move into the lofts.

Rae also expects the area to flourish as a result of the new lofts.

"It's quite possible that there will be a modest resurgence of small retail," he said. "Middle class citizens coming in and out every day is likely to be a good thing."

Forest City claims to engage the community, but Newhallville residents are less enthusiastic about the new apartments. Gauthier said he is wary of the power of large organizations like Yale in his community.

"We don't have a force ready to deal with the huge power that Yale has on influencing the political scene in New Haven," he said. "It's very important that we maintain an active political force like Newhall-

ville Rising and New Haven Rising."

These two groups advocate for increasing the number of jobs in the city that go to city residents instead of people who live outside New Haven and commute. But some see organizing labor as an uphill battle. Although Yale recently promised to create 500 new jobs, the new positions may not be union-affiliated. Yale's relations with its two unions—Local 34 and Local 35—are tense, and it does not recognize or negotiate with the Graduate Employees and Students Organization (GESO). GESO has protested repeatedly on campus for better pay and greater departmental diversity. The union's protests fall on Yale's deaf ears.

"[Yale-New Haven] hospital and Yale spend millions of dollars to change how people look at organized labor," Gauthier said, adding that Yale, Albertus Magnus College, and the city are "marching right through the community and establishing a base to change how that community looks."

Gauthier said he believes in the ability of a good-paying job to turn someone away from drug dealing. By bringing jobs back to Newhallville, Gauthier expects many of the area's problems to dissipate. And he is not alone in this belief—in June over 1,000 New Haven workers called for more jobs opportunities in the city, targeting New Haven's biggest employers: the university and Yale-New Haven Hospital.

Today, much of the city's violent crime still happens in Newhallville. Just this spring, two men robbed a Yale Undergraduate at gunpoint there. Two years ago, an 83-year-old Yale architecture professor was attacked at 32 Lilac Street, the site of a Yale-designed house. Because of the incident, Yale removed the newly installed foundation and ceased construction. Even the U.S. government acknowledges that crime is a problem here. Last year the city got a $1 million Byrne Criminal Justice Innovation grant from the U.S. Department of Justice to strengthen the Newhallville community's relationship with police.

The neighborhoods around Winchester are changing, and not just because of the Lofts. Naparstek called the once vibrant nearby Cardinal Club a "notorious and dangerous bar where there were a lot of violent incidents." The city recently green-lighted the space to become a Café G bakery-cafe.

"I would rather have people buying croissants and expensive coffee than getting shot," Naparstek said. "Is that gentrification? I don't know."

Cities like New Haven are making a comeback across the country, said Naparstek.

"Urban areas of America are getting tremendous interest from young professionals and millennials," he said.

Fewer young people are buying houses and are instead renting homes in cities where they can walk everywhere, Naparstek said.

What are the effects of gentrification? It depends on who you talk to. Greenberg, who grew up in New Haven, said he dislikes the word gentrification for its negative connotation.

"People look at gentrification like it's a rich man's game," he said. Instead of destroying communities, gentrification can improve struggling areas and raise the quality of life for the poor and underprivileged. The same neighborhoods that held vibrant factory communities are now places full of violent crime and drug use, said Greenberg. The Winchester Lofts development is good for Newhallville because it increases the property value of all the houses in the area, he added.

But Greenberg said gentrification and rising real estate do present a significant problem: they price people out. Greenberg compared what is happening in New Haven to areas of New York City like Brooklyn, where he currently lives. Not only does the cost of living rise, but big business also begins to wield undue influence on the community, he said.

"I've watched the process," he said. "Large money will start to dictate the formula of the new town…all these tiny signature places that were part of the DNA of New Haven are starting to be washed away by developers and Yale, who are trying to dictate the shape of the new town," Greenberg said.

Educated Burgher and Culter's Records and Tapes—two single-location stores once on Broadway—have closed permanently, to be replaced by chain stores. This gradual elimination of the city's unique identity troubles Greenberg, who works to preserve New Haven's history whenever he can.

"If you use the history of New Haven, if you celebrate that history you can educate future generations," he said, and it is for history's sake that Greenberg praised the new lofts. Sometimes the only way forward is to look back; this is the philosophy of the new lofts.

"[Forest City] brought back the essence of the building, they celebrated the architecture…Winchester is on the right path," he said.

But Gauthier is of a different mind. He pointed to the Board of Alders' failure to address gentrification in New Haven.

"Nobody is making it an issue right now," he said. "They don't take action in a unified way. Most people who live in Newhallville cannot afford the kind of rents that are being pushed forward," Gauthier said. Long-term homeownership strengthens a community, he added. People care for their houses, respect property, and get to know their neighbors. Many of the Newhallville residents have lived there for upwards of 30 or 40 years. The new tenants of Winchester Lofts, Gauthier fears, will move out after only four or five years.

The high cost of living was also a problem at Winchester a century ago. An opinion piece in the *Winchester Record* praises the power of hard work and exalts industry as a path to a better society. Manual labor was at the center of the Winchester worldview, and any reluctance for this kind of work was immoral, almost unpatriotic.

"What if a man is not willing to produce as much as the other fellow?" asked the *Record*. "That means he is parasitic…We cannot have unless we earn."

Faith in industry, an egalitarian work ethic, a respect for blue collar work—these are elements of New Haven's past that should not be forgotten, even as the city rides the technology boom into the future.

"The conditions in which people toiled [at Winchester] for generations was hard and loud, and sweaty," Greenberg said. Today, the only sweating done at Winchester is on the treadmills in the first floor fitness room.


HIGHER ONE



OUT FOR BLOOD

Will Theranos Revolutionize Medical Testing?

BY **GRACE SHU**

Move over, LabCorp and Quest Diagnostics, there's a new biotech powerhouse hogging the headlines: Theranos, a biotech startup currently valued at over $9 billion, aims to revolutionize blood diagnostics. By offering a cost-and-time effective alternative to traditional lab testing. The company is just emerging from its infancy, but its team's ambition is far from waning. With Elizabeth Holmes, the world's youngest female billionaire, at the helm, plus backing from the likes of Carlos Slim and Henry Kissinger, the enterprise has both scientists and investors talking.

While at Stanford, Holmes developed novel microfluidic techniques and used them to launch her new business. Such technology enables Theranos to run over 30 lab tests in a matter of hours, using only drops of the patient's blood. Through their growing collaboration with Walgreens Wellness Centers, Theranos can bring its product directly to the consumer.

The steps are simple: pick up a lab order from a physician, bring it to the local Walgreens, provide a blood sample via finger stick draw, and receive results later that day. Hoping to make this process even more effortless, Theranos is attempting to eliminate the first step altogether. The company's recent lobbying efforts in Arizona are telling about what they hope to soon make the national norm.

House Bill 2645, entitled "Laboratory Testing Without Physician Order," was given the green light by Arizona Governor Doug Ducey, who signed the bill in mid-April. Ducey staged the signing ceremony at a Theranos location in Scottsdale, AZ, with Holmes present. The bill went into effect in July and has allowed Theranos to continue expanding its services in Arizona.

At the ceremony, Holmes remarked that Theranos "believe[s] Arizona's law can and should serve as a model for the nation for direct access testing."

National legislation with similar provisions would provide Theranos with enough leverage to overtake LabCorp and Quest Diagnostics and emerge as the dominant lab testing company in the field.

But the chance of federal legislation passing in the near future remains slim because of the obstacles Theranos is bound to hit. Legislation will likely face major opposition from the lab companies who currently provide the majority of lab tests done in America.

Dr. Kavita Patel, the Managing Director of Clinical Transformation at the Brookings Institution's Center for Health Policy and a current practicing physician at Johns Hopkins Medicine, told *The Politic*, "We'll see in Arizona how much is initiated by a patient and what the downstream effects



are." According to Patel, those effects concern "how much of what a patient initiates might result in false-positive and false-negative" results in comparison to traditional lab testing through a physician.

False-positive and false-negative outcomes are the results of mistakes in lab testing that can erroneously report the presence or absence of a disease.

Patel described a scenario in which every person in the U.S. submits herself to a test for Lyme disease, which has a false positive rate of 2 to 3 percent, through Theranos's self testing. The combination of that percentage and the large patient pool will result in a significant number of results declaring a false-positive. This scenario raises some questions. Who would handle the hundreds of thousands of people with incorrect results? Who would be liable for the error? Patel noted that when a patient initiates a test that results in either a false-positive or a false-negative, the share of culpability held by the provider and physician still remains unclear. Since Arizona's new law enables patients to bypass seeing a physician entirely, the physician could claim to have played no part in the diagnosis altogether.

Although Patel expressed her reservations regarding House Bill 2645's potential implications for any federal legislation, she lauded the company for its price transparency. All Theranos's test prices are conveniently listed on its website, with no individual test price exceeding 50 percent of Medicare reimbursement costs. That alone could save the current healthcare industry billions of dollars, providing uninsured



ABOVE: Theranos headquarters in Palo Alto, CA. The building once belonged to Facebook, before it was passed over to Theranos in 2012.

"National legislation with similar provisions would provide Theranos with enough leverage to overtake LabCorp and Quest Diagnostics and emerge as the dominant lab testing company in the field."

patients with a cheaper alternative to expensive lab testing via the doctor's office.

Dr. Mark McClellan, a senior fellow and director of the Health Care Innovation and Value Initiative at the Brookings Institution, implied that there is a growing trend in healthcare to modify pricing so that "a patient can best meet his or her medical needs at the lowest price."

McClellan went on to add that given Theranos's "more efficient technology," the company could potentially "drive down those payments" made by and to Medicare, insurance providers and labs to ensure a lower overall cost for the patient. Yet the issue is more nuanced than that, for even if such patients could afford testing, they would still need to consider the possibility of taking further action if the results for a particular disease are positive. Suppose they do make an appointment at a doctor's office and then hand the physician their Theranos test results; the doctor is likely to have them submit to testing again in order to verify the diagnosis.

As a result, patients would end up spending even more money than if they had simply chosen the standard lab testing. One method through which Theranos could combat this issue is to build up its scientific credentials through more transparency about its technology. In the business sector, the company is formidable. *Fortune* notes that it has "three former cabinet secretaries, two former senators, and retired military brass" on its board. However, there appears to be a stark contrast between Theranos's copious business sponsors and its scientific backing.

In fact, despite the buzz generated, some members of the scientific community remain unconvinced, citing Theranos' lack of peer reviews as a reason for their skepticism. The company guards the secrets of its trade closely, which can be a double edged sword. On the one hand, it ensures that the technology remains under wraps, preventing other companies from mimicking its processes. On the other hand, Theranos has yet to subject its findings to the scrutiny of other scientists in the field, which weakens the legitimacy of its results.

Dr. Weian Zhao is the principal investigator at a stem cell and biomedical engineering lab at the University of California, Irvine, who conducts similar work utilizing microfluidics as a tool for blood diagnostics.

He told *The Politic* that he understood Theranos' reluctance to publish information about its technology, especially "from a business perspective," because the company is "not [technically] required to publish anything."

Despite the little data made publicly available, Zhao did not doubt the technology Theranos purports to possess, as some of his peers may. The number of labs, including his own, incorporating microfluidics into their experiments has skyrocketed in recent years. These labs produce numerous scientific articles that attest to the ability of this newfound technology to accomplish tasks such as those necessary for Theranos. As a result, Zhao understands Theranos' heavy focus on advertising and business, which he commended as successful in allowing the company to achieve what it has done thus far.

However, he was less optimistic of Theranos's claims that it plans to reinvent the current definition of diagnosis. He expressed hesitance because "they do not necessarily change the paradigm of early detection."

Biomarkers, which can indicate the presence of a disease in the body, "can be extremely low concentration at an early stage," and since Theranos "only measure[s] those biomarkers in snapshots in a small volume," he explained, "their technology is unable

"Although Theranos has gripped the world with its revolutionary blood diagnostics and bold claims, it remains clear that it still has a long way to go before it solidifies itself as a mainstream alternative to traditional lab testing."

to address that fact," and therefore unable to truly revolutionize early detection.

Their main selling point, in Zhao's opinion, lies in the fact that they present an alternative method to current testing that saves patients both money and time. Here, Zhao praised Theranos for its effective breakthroughs in the biotech industry, which could lead to a more concentrated effort in perfecting the art of microfluidics and other early detection techniques.

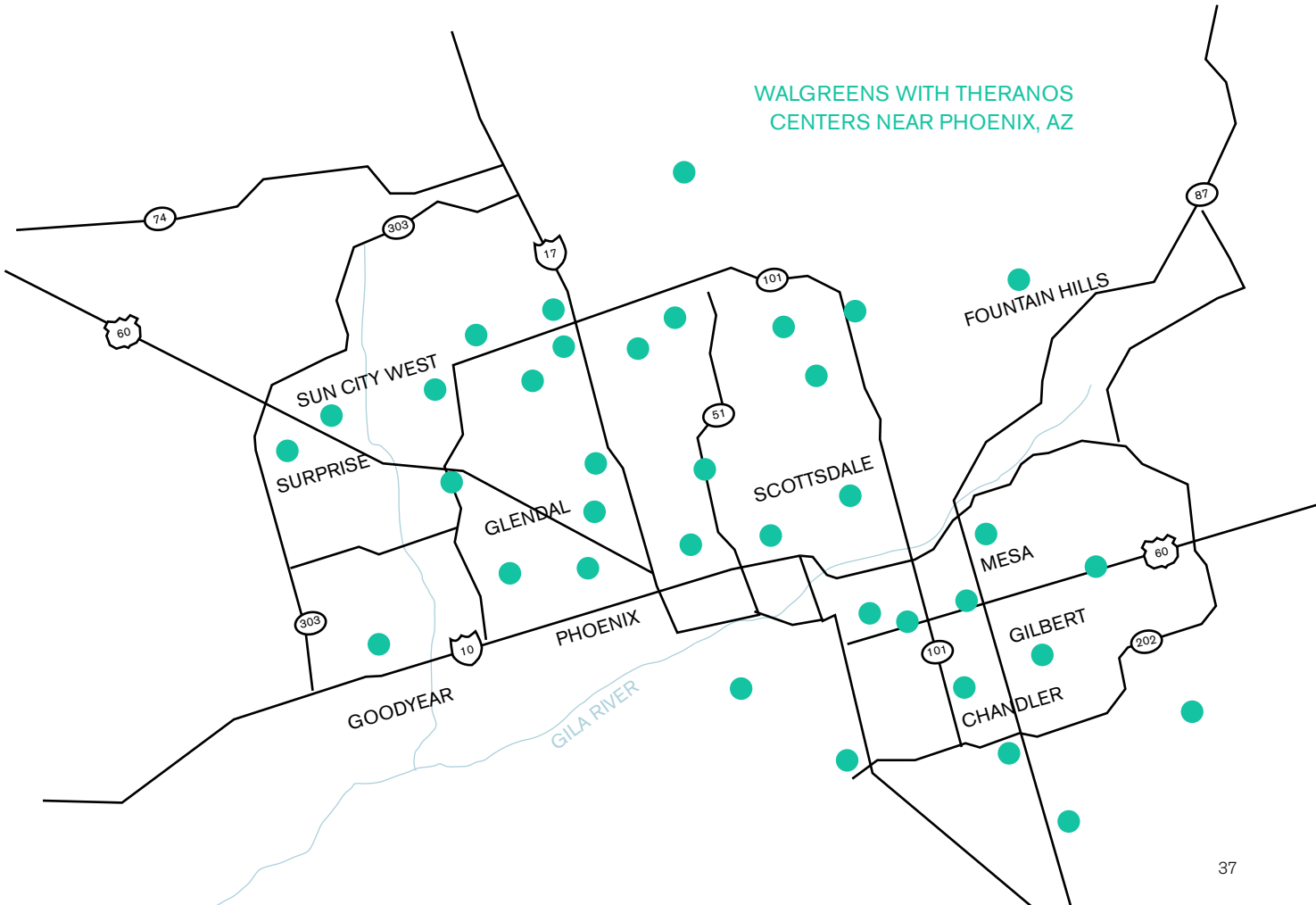
Perhaps the issue with early detection lies less with the actual diagnosis, but with what comes after it.

Jeremy Barofsky, the Brookings Institution's Okun-Model Fellow, told *The Politic* that the "problem of follow-up" after a patient receives his or her results could prove to be "much more difficult" than obtaining a diagnosis.

Barofsky went on to detail a specific scenario wherein someone under financial stress or with a low income receives the diagnosis of diabetes after being able to afford the testing through Theranos. Barofsky argued that despite having this knowledge, it would be difficult to guess what exactly the patient would do about it. After all, it is one thing to spend a certain amount of money on a single lab test; it's another to have to constantly shell out money over the course of a lifetime to deal with a noncommunicable disease such as diabetes. Here, information and technology could help to ensure that patients are in constant communication with the health system. Whether it is through real time data, providing reminders, or other methods, Barofsky seemed confident that startups could drive more interaction than the standard doctor's appointment followed by a period of stagnancy for several months.

Although Theranos has gripped the world with its revolutionary blood diagnostics and bold claims, it remains clear that it still has a long way to go before it solidifies itself as a mainstream alternative to traditional lab testing. The company is equal parts hype and potential, pitching its low costs and accessibility to the world in a revolutionary manner.

Theranos's efforts almost sound too good to be true but the company has technology, innovation, and some of the world's smartest minds on its side—now all it needs is the general public, which may be harder to convince than it assumes.





The Politic's *Ward 1 Correspondent, Diego Fernandez-Pages, sits down with Sarah Eidelson and Ugonna Eze, candidates for New Haven's Ward 1 Alder.*

Sarah Eidelson walks in a few minutes late. She is coming from her day job (because alders only work part-time), doing graphic design for Yale's unions. She double majored in American studies and art while she was an undergraduate in Jonathan Edwards. Hers was a typical college story; she took her first art class junior year and never looked back. She designs her own campaign posters too—the yellow ones, with the buildings from around the city, are all her own creation.

Sarah is not your typical politician: she's soft-spoken, but not quiet; she's astute, but not intimidating. While we conversed, she would take time to think about her answers—she's careful with her responses, perhaps unlike many pundits and lawmakers who grace our TV screens from Capitol Hill.

She freely admits, "I had never thought of myself as a very public person, or a kind of leader who's up front and giving speeches."

The question remains: how did Eidelson, an atypical politician, get to an elected position?

It began at home, in the outskirts of Philadelphia. Her family is Jewish, and her parents are both progressive psychologists. Her mother evaluates and testifies as an expert witness on behalf of torture survivors seeking asylum in the United States. Her father writes about psychology as it relates to progressive political change, focusing on torture as well. For her mother's birthday last year, Eidelson gave her a map with pins marking the places with the people whose lives she's saved.

"It's really inspiring to me," she says emphatically.

Despite a staunchly leftist upbringing, Eidelson was enrolled in a conservative Jewish high school. Because of her political values, she frequently butted heads with administrators.

"I am queer, and that was not okay at my school," she reflects.

Her school did not allow Eidelson and her friends to start a gay-straight alliance. Instead, it provided a club known as 'TASK.'

"It stands for Teaching Acceptance and Sharing Knowledge, or something like that—it was basically a diversity club," she explains.

There was no space for students to explore other parts of their identities: their sexualities, racial backgrounds, genders, or their intersecting aspects.

"The environment around the LGBTQ community was not friendly," she says, "so I was part of a group of students fighting tooth and nail with the administration to let us have a space."

It would be her first important foray into activism and pushing for

something that was important to her and to her community. Eventually, her group's efforts paid off when they founded The Alliance. She recognizes the lack of "LGBTQ" in any part of the name but is proud that it provided a space for a few different people to come out.

Coming to Yale was in many ways a development of her involvement with activism.

"I think I came to Yale in part wanting to learn how [structural change] happens on a larger scale," she says. She also wanted to get more involved in activist efforts outside of class.

Out of her endeavors came one of her most meaningful memories from Yale. After collecting over 1300 signatures for a petition to get rid of the student contribution, she helped host Speak Out in Dwight Hall, so students on financial aid would have a space to share their experiences. Eidelson describes the event as "overwhelming," both because of the number of people who attended and the quality of the stories they told. They talked about how to split the cost of an Ikea couch and how to earn enough money at Yale to send home to their families.

The student contribution was not the only thing she protested. She and a group of friends started a group called the Responsible Endowment Project (REP) that looked into the ethics of Yale's investment practices.

"Our campaign was about pushing [the Yale administration] to be more transparent in their practices so students could engage more actively in conversation around that," she says.

Some of REP's legacy lives on—in Fossil Free Yale, for example, which still aims to pressure the administration to divest from fossil fuel companies.

One of her most important experiences was working in the Community Voter Project over a summer in New Haven with a Dwight Hall fellowship. The project helps increase voter engagement and community responsibility in underprivileged neighborhoods around the city. One day that summer, as Eidelson was out canvassing in Dixwell, an eleven year old boy was shot by a stray bullet from a gunfight that had broken out nearby.

Sarah is visibly moved as she tells the story. "He was just hanging out by the market in the daylight, and he [ended up being] okay—but it shifted the tenor of the conversation, because people's fears were revealed to be completely valid."

Her experience in New Haven that summer, surrounded by people who lived much differently from Yale students, inspired her run for office.

"Honestly, before I decided to run for Ward 1, I never in a million years imagined that I would've run for elected office. It's not a thing that I aspired to," she confesses.

It was not an easy transition for Eidelson to make. She found it difficult to assume the leadership role that her constituents expected her to fulfill.

"But as we did the work and had hundreds and hundreds of conversations with students about the city we all wanted to live in," she tells, "it was incredibly inspiring to see how much my fellow students wanted to be a part of making New Haven stronger." Eidelson saw herself as a way to bring that about.

After she was elected, Eidelson began building relationships with the other alders, since New Haveners are often skeptical about Yalies. She describes her first day as an alder sitting in the wrong seat.

"My colleague came into the room and saw me in his seat and said, 'there goes Yale, taking over the Hill as per usual.' He was teasing me, but it was symbolic of some very real dynamics," she remarks.

Sarah's approach to governing became one of learning and relationship building, and eventually, it paid off. Eidelson was elected to the leadership of the Youth Committee, which, to her, "felt like a quantum leap from when we started out."

Sarah Eidelson saw herself as a part of New Haven ever since she came to Yale, but she didn't consider it her home until graduation. Today, living in the city and not on campus, she feels connected to both Yale and the community beyond its borders.

More than anything, she respects the people of the city, and as she invested more and more of her time into the neighborhoods of the city, she felt like she was becoming a part of them.

"It's the kind of thing that you don't notice until it's already happened," she chuckles.

We have been talking for an hour, and it is getting late. We wrap up the conversation, talking about our plans for the night and the work we both had left to do—hers governing, mine writing a paper for class. We stand up; she smiles at me and gives me a hug, and answers one last question:

"My favorite dining hall is JE. JE's the best—that's an easy question."

It's been twenty minutes, and Ugonna Eze '16, candidate for Ward 1 Alder, has yet to arrive. I've been doing some readings for a philosophy class, and my tea is almost finished. Blue State is Blue State; mundane chatter about classes and clubs fills the background. Suddenly, around the corner, appears Ugonna: apologizing profusely, he sits down across from me.

"I just ran into a friend I hadn't seen in, like, eight months," he explains, "and then time just got away from me while we were talking."

Ugonna is tall but not particularly so. He's got an easy smile and expectant eyes that look intently at wherever they're directed. We stand and make small talk before sitting down, chatting about the usual: classes, work, the weather.

"What's that you're reading?" he asks, pointing to my book. And with that, we begin a brief conversation about Plato and philosophy, as though we were the best of friends. This was our first time talking.

As it turns out, Eze is a philosophy major: "I can't keep myself away," he says, sighing.

International relations is also an "academic interest," and he's pursuing that by doubling with global affairs. The diversity of his interests, he asserts, comes from his family: his parents, both from Nigeria, inspired him to read everything from fiction to political philosophy.

"My dad would read a lot, and we had Plato and Shakespeare and all sorts of books all around the house," he explains.

Eze's family is more than a source of inspiration: they represent his primary motivation, the driving force behind his ambitions, beyond his school life and reading list. For him, the best part of the race for alder "has been making my parents proud."

When he talks about his background, Eze makes it clear that his successes come from his parents' hard work. He grew up in a violent neighborhood of the Bronx. It was his family that afforded him a chance at success by moving to a significantly more expensive district with much better schools in the Hudson River Valley.

"My parents worked 12-, 14-hour days. They work really hard for my sister and me," he says thoughtfully.

Both of Eze's parents immigrated to the United States from Nigeria. Both were also "dirt poor," his father one of seven children and his mother one of five. Neither was afforded equal opportunities in education. Eze's father was never able to go to an organized school, since they were all closed—so he taught himself to read and write, and eventually studied nursing in a formal university. His mother took the Nigerian National Exam to enter higher education and scored perfectly, but a richer student in her school bought her scores from the administration and passed them under his own name. After that, she was ineligible for entrance to the best universities.

Nevertheless, both of Eze's parents worked their way to the United States, gaining professional visas as nurses and moving to New York in the '90s. Growing up there was difficult.

"I experienced a lot of issues with gangs, and violence… I had a very tough high school experience," Eze affirms.

But his family remained close, supporting him through high school and into college. When it comes to his successes and getting to Yale, he stays humble.

"It wouldn't have been possible," Eze says, "without my folks."

Being at Yale has been fulfilling for Eze. He is active in the Black Men's Union, a former speaker of the Yale Political Union, and a valued member of the Conservative Party. For Eze, the Party is a place where he can discuss the interests he shared with his father at home.

"My dad would read a lot…and coming to Yale and to the CP, I met so many smart people who were reading and discussing so much, that I felt right at home," Eze says.

As we sit in Blue State, Ugonna often brings up "molding his identity." One potential conflict stood out: being a conservative at Yale, a place notorious for its progressive student body. As a member of the Conservative Party of the YPU, Eze has certainly explored the different facets of the political right at Yale. But in the larger community, there is nothing especially uncomfortable about having a different political ideology. If anything, it's constructive for Eze.

"I love debating and talking and figuring things out with people—my friends know me as a guy who is a conservative but who likes having a conversation," Eze says.

In that sense, Eze has always been the odd one out. He is the only conservative in his family and his sister works for a Democratic Super PAC. But, he assures me, "It's been good for me. As I've been shaping my ideas, it's been good to hear opinions from all different sides."

For Eze, the diversity of opinion

at Yale has helped develop his views leading up to the November 3 election.

"Our first public event was on environmentalism," he mentions. "Yeah, I'm a conservative, but I care about left-wing topics."

Eze's time at Yale has in many ways been characterized by his relationship to the city of New Haven, a place he identifies with his upbringing in the Bronx, and in which he's had many valuable experiences. From talking to residents on the Green to conversations with his barber on Whalley, Eze has made an effort to get to know Yale's host city and has considered New Haven his home from the moment he started as a freshman.

"It's a beautiful city," he notes, "and there's a strong tenacity of spirit in New Haven that I can really relate to."

He constantly draws on his experiences in the Bronx when talking about the city. At one point, he mentions one of the BMU's mentoring programs.

"I was a math mentor a couple of years ago, and one of the mentees at Hillhouse High School came up to me and told me that he didn't know that a black man from the Bronx could major in math at Yale," he says. It's moments like these that make Eze feel connected to the Elm City in a way that he says "every Yalie should."

But the most fulfilling thing for Ugonna has been watching the Elm City progress.

"It's amazing to see New Haven fight," he says. Furthermore, he thinks that Yale students have an important place in that community, especially in giving back.

Running for alder is, for Eze, the best way to give back to a community about which he cares deeply.

"I've been privileged to have a platform where people can hear my voice," he explains. "I want to convey my thoughts and feelings in the right way, and it's a constant thought—am I doing this right?"

If he wins, Eze says he will work to bring about changing Yalies' perspectives on New Haven. If he doesn't? That, he admits, is not something he thinks about too often.

"I go where I'm led, where I can best supply my talents," he says. And he hasn't thought about his life after Yale too much either. "I have a vague idea of some things I want to do: write a book, one on philosophy, one fiction. I want to be able to raise a family... I like writing 'music.' I might pursue a J.D./Ph.D. at some point." He likes focusing on the present.

The conversation is wrapping up—he's got another friend to meet.

"My greatest strength is that I care a lot about people," he tells me, and I can't help thinking of the beginning of our conversation.

"My greatest weakness is that sometimes I give too much of myself. I see someone on the street, and I spend two hours talking to them, even when I have an assignment due that afternoon."

Before we part, I ask him what his favorite dining hall is. "Commons," he responds. "I really appreciate that [it's] a central spot, where everyone can come." And with that—a democratic statement if I have ever heard one—he shakes my hand and leaves, thanking me for a good conversation.



PENN $2,282,000

STANFORD $2,150,000

Doing More With Less

The Yale College Council's Budget Battle

BY **JOEY YE**

At 8 a.m. on a typical Saturday, most Yale students are sound asleep, waiting for the more welcoming hours of late morning to greet the world. But April 25 was no typical Saturday. It was Spring Fling. And by 8 p.m., hundreds of students were already out of bed and well on their way to party.

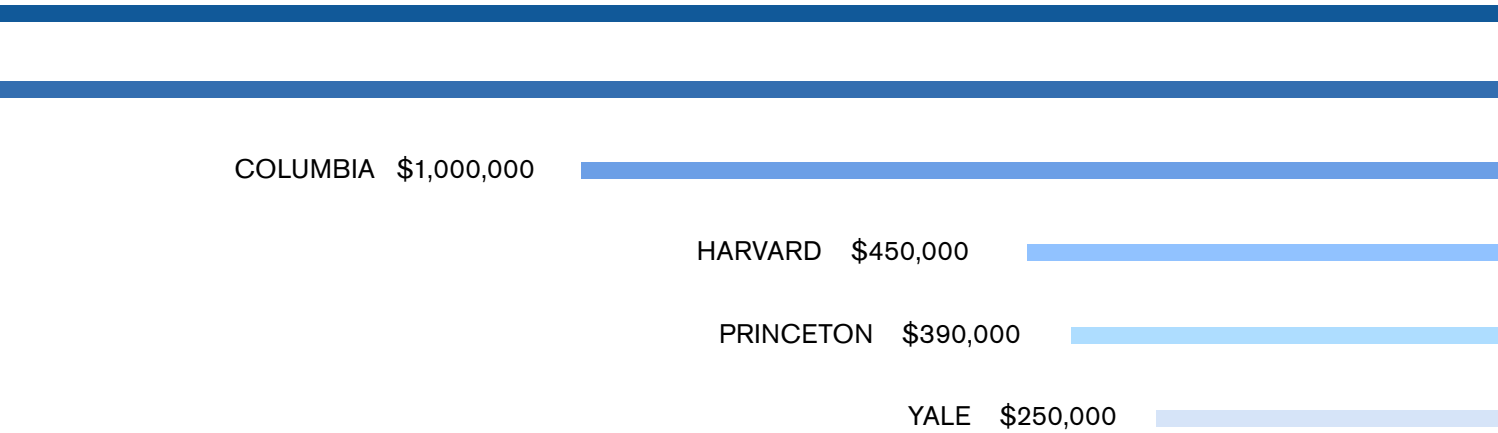
Like any other Spring Fling, last year's festivities began early in the day and lasted well into the night. Before the concert officially began at 6 p.m., revelers packed fraternities, houses belonging to athletic teams, and upperclassmen suites. Red Bull's student representatives made the rounds on Old Campus, bestowing the crowd with large amounts of the energy drink to keep them fueled until the last performance at 9 p.m.

At 8 p.m., British diva Jessie J took the stage for her headliner set. Yale was only one of many stops for Jessie J, who had already performed at Harvard's Spring Fling equivalent, Yardfest, and was set to appear at Brandeis University for its Springfest. Jessie J was the first female artist to headline Spring Fling since 1998, when the Indigo Girls took the Yale stage. Since then, Old Campus has seen performances from all over the spectrum, from Diplo's sinister trap beats to Matt and Kim's exuberant pop rock anthems. But with all of these big names gathered in one place each year, how much does it actually cost the YCC to have these artists perform?

LAST YEAR, THE YCC'S BUDGET totaled $250,000. Though the YCC is unable to disclose the official cost of hiring the performers due to a privacy clause in their contract, it has publicized that it allocates more than three quarters of its annual budget solely to hosting the Spring Fling concert. A large portion of this money comes from the student activities fee which, according to the approved YCC budget for the 2014-15 academic year, was projected to allocate $191,000 to the YCC. Each year the council also receives an additional $40,000 from the University President's Office, solely for the purpose of bolstering the Spring Fling budget. This left $30,000 to be split among the remaining fall and spring semester events, including the Harvard-Yale football game, the Iron Chef cooking competition, and the Mr. Yale pageant. This year, that total rose to $52,500.

As in past years, the YCC was able to secure the headline artist for a significantly lower price compared to the artist's other bookings for that year. Former YCC Spring Fling Committee Chair Thomas Marano '16 attributed the low cost to the fact that the committee was able to book Jessie J a week prior to the October 13 release of her third album "Sweet Talker." The album featured the single "Bang Bang," which subsequently peaked at number six on Billboard's Hot 100.

Still, the amount saved through last year's early contract signing is not nearly enough to offset the YCC's budget gap when compared to those of student governments at other institutions of higher learning. Compared to other private universities, Yale spends significantly less on its spring concert. The University of Pennsylvania's spring fling concert has a budget of $180,000 for talent and $250,000 for production, explained Penn Undergraduate Assembly Treasurer Kat McKay, a junior at the university. Further, Penn chooses to charge its students to attend its spring concert. Last year, students were charged $55 for floor passes and $45 for general admission tickets, while non-Penn students were able to purchase



general admission tickets for $80. It also allocates a total of $33,850 to its fall concert.

Earlier this year, Penn's Undergraduate Assembly reported a total budget of $2,282,000 for the 2015-16 academic school year. McKay said that while the student government does not have its own endowment, its funds are donated directly from the University of Pennsylvania's Board of Trustees. In addition, she said, the budget usually increases by about 3.3% per year.

"The UA funds all six [Penn student government branches] and elements of a few other initiatives, like our freshman pre-orientation programs and New Student Orientation," McKay told *The Politic*. "The majority of the budget goes to the Student Activities Council and the Student Committee on Undergraduate Education to support student clubs and speaker events, Fling, and concerts and parties open to everyone."

Compared to its Ivy League peers, the YCC operates on a particularly small budget. Former Columbia University Student Council President Bailinson said that the undergraduate governing body has a yearly budget of just under $1 million, while at Harvard, the Undergraduate Council works with an annual stipend of $450,000. Similarly, the Princeton Undergraduate Student Government has an approved budget of $390,000 for the fall of 2015.

Even outside of the Ivy League, the disparity is significant. Similar to Penn, Stanford University also maintains significant funds for its student government. Jackson Beard, Chair of the Appropriations Committee for the 16th Undergraduate Senate of Stanford, told *The Politic* that around $2.1 to $2.2 million is allocated to its undergraduate student government. This is only a small portion of the $15 million endowment of the Associated Students of Stanford University, an entity representing all of the currently enrolled students at Stanford University.

"Because our budget depends on how much we decide we need, every year there's a possibility of it adjusting," Beard said. "The amount we charge students per quarter [in the student activities fee] is determined by how much we approve student groups for in the spring. For example, a group that throws all the concerts on campus, if they decide they need this many artists on campus, and students approve the funding, then we can adjust the budget."

THIS SEMESTER THE STUDENT activities fee for Yale undergraduates is $125, a $50 increase from last semester's charge. The YCC's budget has increased by about $130,000 this year because of the student activities fee, YCC President Joe English '17 said, adding that while students are able to opt out of paying the fee, most generally did not. He noted also that the fee can be covered by financial aid.

Despite being below the Ivy League average of $159.57, Yale's fee was not the lowest student activities fee last year (though it was not off by much). The most expensive fee was charged by the University of Pennsylvania at $3,150 per year, more than double Columbia University's $1,396 fee, the next highest in the Ivy League. Of Columbia's annual general student life fee, $216 was allocated to student activities. On the other end, Harvard and Princeton had the lowest fees per annum, reporting $75 and $65 respectively. President of the Harvard Council Ava Nasrollahzadeh said that

like at Yale, students at Harvard are eligible to waive the fee, though it comprises the majority of the undergraduate council's funds.

But beyond a lack of funding for Spring Fling, what other problems does a small student government budget pose? Beard said the Stanford Undergraduate Senate generally allocates around $300,000 to $400,000 to student groups on campus, well in excess of the total YCC budget. The Harvard Undergraduate Council also distributes $300,000 in funds to student groups across the college campus, Nasrollahzadeh said. English noted that the interest generated by the Stanford Undergraduate Senate's budget would more than double the YCC budget. He added that if the YCC possessed comparable funds, the organization would be able to solve a broad range of campus issues prevalent last semester, citing the student pushes for renovations of the African American and Asian cultural houses as examples.

"The big sticking point, and this goes for every single project that [the YCC] does, is not policy, not tradition, not access to faculty; it comes down to money," English told *The Politic*. "If we had more money it would be so much easier to buy more iPhone chargers for Bass and to fix the basement of La Casa. Same for mental health services. It's a big problem because [the administration doesn't] have the money. Administrators want the same things we do, they just don't have the funding. They are hearing the students, but they don't have the funding to effect real change."

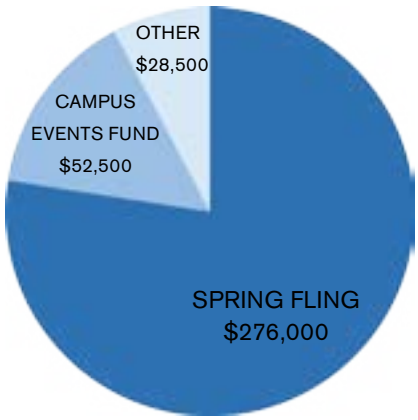
DOES A LACK OF FUNDING impede the YCC's ability to enact change on campus? English argued that without a sizeable budget of its own, the YCC is unable to effectively voice concerns against the University, in part because the organization is paid for by the school. He said that if the council were able to grow a part of an endowment each year, it would be able to cultivate a better perception of student government and gain more "leverage" within the student body. This could be done through increased funding to undergraduate organizations as well as hosting more YCC sponsored events, English explained. Former YCC President Michael Herbert '16 agreed, noting that the relatively small budget is a hindrance in terms of hosting events and providing incentives for students to participate in the YCC.

On the other hand, even with relatively larger budgets, both Princeton and Harvard have recently experienced significant apathy toward their student governments. In December of 2014, Will Gansa, a current junior at Princeton University, competed in a runoff with Ella Cheng for the undergraduate student government presidency. What was most notable about this election was not that he gained more votes than the body's former vice president, nor that Gansa had no prior experience with student government. It was the fact that he ran on a joke platform and intended to make fun of the student government, pledging to bring waffle fries and ripe fruit to campus. Though he ultimately did not win, voter turnout for the election was 40 percent higher than the previous year.

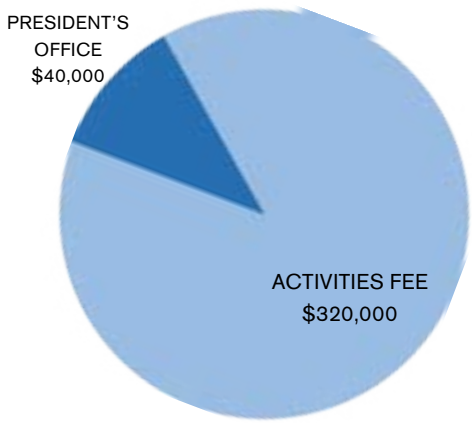
A year earlier, in 2013, the same situation occurred at Harvard with one difference—the joke ticket won the presidency. With no experience on the council and after promising thicker toilet paper, junior roommates Sam Clark and Gus Mayopoulus were elected president and vice president of the Harvard Undergraduate Council, respectively, by a margin of more than 150 votes. Though both initially agreed to resign upon the release of the election results, Mayopoulus ultimately went on to assume the council's presidency.

After serving for a year on the council with Mayopoulus, Nasrollahzadeh said she learned many "valuable lessons" from both Mayopoulus and Clark.

HOW THE '15-16 BUDGET WILL BE SPENT



THE SOURCES OF THE '15-16 BUDGET



> "The term of student government is a misnomer; it's not a government in that it doesn't actually have any authority. When it's perceived as self-important or self-aggrandizing, that's when you have more negativity [from the student body]."
>
> Michael Herbert, YCC President '16

"Having one of the members of the joke ticket be our president gave the council the opportunity to reassess its relationship with the students and to also reassess the dynamic of the council community internally," she said.

While the council members serve as representatives of the students, she added that it was important to remember the council members' other role: as students themselves. What does this say about Yale? In 2014, Michael Herbert was elected as president of YCC, despite his lack of previous experience on the council. Herbert said being an "outsider" may have helped him become president. While he admitted that the student government's lack of power and apparent arrogance may lead to jokes, he attributed part of his success as a candidate to addressing accusations head on.

"The term of student government is a misnomer it's not a government in that it doesn't actually have any authority," Herbert said. "When it's perceived as self-important or self-aggrandizing, that's when you have more negativity [from the student body]."

During Herbert's presidency, the YCC addressed a number of student concerns. The council lobbied the university administration to halt the student income contribution for students receiving financial aid and convinced the administration to establish gender neutral housing for sophomores. At the end of the 2014-15 academic year, Yale College Dean Jonathan Holloway announced a number of reforms to Yale's withdrawal and admission policies, including extending the period of time during which students can request a leave of absence. Further, the University released a new website detailing available mental health resources and expanded the number of clinicians available to students on campus.

Over the last year, student governments across the country have all been dealing with similar issues, from improving mental health policies to divesting from fossil fuels. Jane Meyer, President of the Penn Undergraduate Assembly, said the assembly recently helped implement the PEN anti-violence educators program - a peer led sexual assault prevention program. Nasrollahzadeh said that, last semester, the Harvard Undergraduate Council launched Side By Side, a gender equality campaign also meant to push forth the conversation surrounding campus sexual assault. At Princeton, Cheng released a report addressing how open the school's lawn clubs are to all students.

Herbert agreed that student engagement at Yale on a number of issues, from sexual assault policies to mental health resources, has given the YCC momentum to catalyze change within the university. Even with a relatively small budget, the YCC offers Yale students the best chance to have a direct impact on the community, he said, adding that students should be invested in the organization as their representative to the administration.

"Michael's right in that things will never change if the students don't back us," English said. "But in this time right now, I do feel that the YCC has more support and goodwill than it has had in past years."

Truth Matters: A Journey into the World of Birther Conspiracy Theorists

BY **GABRIEL GROZ**

Donald Trump surveys the crowded town hall, his face locked in an expression that can only be described as a smiling scowl. His eyes finally settle on a middle-aged man in the front row.

“OK, this man. I like this guy,” he remarks.

The room is filled to the brim with ecstatic supporters, but only one gets the pleasure of asking “The Donald” the first question.

In an exchange that has since been replayed countless times, the man asserts that President Obama is a foreign-born Muslim and that the country is filled with “training camps, growing, where they want to kill us.” His emotion visible, his voice straining, the man asks, “When can we get *rid* of them?”

Throughout the question, Trump nods along, seeming to agree with the questioner. He responds quickly, giving a boilerplate answer: "You know, a lot of people are saying that and a lot of people are saying that bad things are happening. We're going to be looking at that and a lot of other things."

Trump's response, as revealing as it is of the candidate's refusal to negate the racism of his supporters, says very little about his actual beliefs or policies. It's difficult to discern when he's being serious and when he's just trying to please a voter. But one thing about his response is absolutely serious, and frighteningly so: many people do agree with this now-infamous Trump supporter.

A September poll from Public Policy Polling found that a shockingly low 29% of GOP primary voters believe that Obama was born in the United States. What's more, the same poll found that 40% of Republican voters believe that Texas Senator Ted Cruz—an American citizen who has openly talked about his Canadian nationality—was born in the United States. In sum: more Republicans believe that Cruz was born in America than they do Obama.

This poll isn't an anomaly. A September CNN poll found that 43% of Republican primary voters, and a full two-thirds of Trump supporters, still believe that Obama is a Muslim.

These polling results beg the question: What kind of worldview must one have to subscribe to these kinds of theories? And under what broader ideological and historical framework do these ideas fall?

To answer these questions requires a trip to what could be described as an alternate reality.

A parallel universe exists in the imagination of the American radical right, a universe that is invisible to most Americans. Mainstream news sources don't endorse conspiracy theories, and even candidates who count conspiracy theorists among their supporters, such as Donald Trump and Ben Carson, don't delineate the full details of what they believe. Even when major news outlets announce the results of opinion polls, they barely scratch the surface of what their respondents actually think. When, for instance, a full 70% of GOP primary respondents answer that they do not believe that President Obama was born in the United States, they are not asked to explain where they do believe he was born.

But there is a place where the full worldview of the American extreme right is laid bare in remarkable translucency: YouTube. With one YouTube search you can enter a radically different world, a world in which President Obama is an agent of a malicious New World Order, FEMA is setting up concentration camps in Wyoming, Eric Holder is in league with Los Zetas and the national implementation of Sharia is imminent. The cardinal belief, however, the axiom by which this brave new world operates, is that President Obama is not an American citizen.

The two-word search "Obama Birth" retrieves a colossal 1,260,000 distinct YouTube hits. When controlled for view count and recent view history, the search results show many videos with view counts in the high millions and high view growth rates, indicating abundant and sustained interest in President Obama's birth.

The most popular conspiracy video retrieved by the search, posted by a YouTuber with the alias "Conservative Watchman," has over 6,000,000 views and the title "Not Natural Born—TRUTH MATTERS." A patchwork of clips from right wing documentaries and selectively edited footage from President Obama's press conferences, it is almost the Platonic ideal of the right wing anti-Obama citizenship conspiracy video. In quick succession, it hits all the movement's talking points. First a radio host tells us that Obama is foreign born, specifically Kenyan. Then a lawyer named Philip Berg, since disbarred, tells us that Obama is bent on destroying the Constitution. Finally, a series of clips of Obama mentioning Muslim family members and saying the Arabic phrase for welcome, *as-salamu aleikum*, is supposed to convince the viewer that the president is a confirmed Muslim.

These birther videos do not exist in a vacuum. Instead, they are part of a sustained and extant movement that has retained an astoundingly large viewership over the past seven years. Because I watched dozens of conspiracy videos for the purpose of writing this article, YouTube began to treat me as it would a conspiracy theorist. Instead of folk songs and

Bruce Springsteen hits, my "suggested videos" docket began to show conspiracy videos, and increasingly extreme ones at that. It did not take long for my YouTube feed to become saturated with conspiracy content. In a crop that included a video from 2014 alleging that Obama has devil's horns, perhaps the most alarming was a video called "Is Obama really Osama Bin Laden?"

The film begins with a full-screen image: a bright yellow Gadsden flag, the kind seen at Tea Party protests and, more recently, at Donald Trump rallies. As the opening lines of Carmina Burana play in the background, an image of President Obama comes into focus. Latin words can be heard, chanting: "*O Fortuna! Velut luna! Statu variabilis!*" An image of Osama Bin Laden's face then appears to President Obama's left. In an incoherent and bizarre sequence that almost eludes written description, President Obama's eyes are transposed onto Bin Laden's face. All-caps captions declare the two faces to be a perfect match. By now Carmina Burana has reached its climax, and the video becomes even more surreal. Obama's official Senate portrait appears next to an early image of Bin Laden and, as the rococo flourishes of Carmina Burana get louder and louder, the two portraits become one.

The video's quality can be best described as primitive, resembling a middle school student's first PowerPoint presentation. And that doesn't even account for the video's frighteningly unhinged content. Its closest parallel might be *Star Wars Episode III* (spoiler ahead), *Revenge of the Sith*, in which the virtuous Chancellor Palpatine is actually revealed to be the evil Darth Sidious. So why should anyone care about a crank video made by someone with minimal Photoshop skills? Because five million people cared enough to watch it. It is clear that a vigorous conspiratorial subculture exists beneath the fabric of American politics, a subculture that is impenetrably bizarre to all those who don't subscribe to it.

Matthew Jacobson is a professor of history and american studies at Yale who studies the intersection of race, nativism and political culture. He has published widely on politics of nativism, including a book that examines the 1962 film *The Manchurian Candidate*, a film one can see as a clear ideological predecessor to today's conspiratorial YouTube videos. This YouTube subculture, Jacobson told *The Politic*, reveals "a deep sense of white displacement" felt among the conspiratorial radical right—the notion that the country's basic political institutions have been subverted by undeserving foreigners.

> These birther videos do not exist in a vacuum. Instead, they are part of a sustained and extant movement that has retained an astoundingly large viewership over the past seven years.

"I remember seeing an extraordinary on-the-street interview of a woman, conducted shortly after President Obama was elected," he said. "She was crying, almost hysterically, saying that she had lost her country."

This anger at the prospect of losing one's country to a minority group, Jacobson added, is no new phenomenon in America.

Jacobson delineated three common features of conspiracy theories: distance from reality, anti-government sentiment, and syncretism.

"You have theories that are so out there," he elaborated, "such as that Bin Laden conspiracy, that they are unhinged from reality itself. This makes a precise ideological categorization difficult."

But, he said, they all seem to stem from an extreme mistrust of government.

"Most theories very clearly relate to the long standing anti-government sentiment in American political discourse—the movements against government programs including Social Security, Great Society and, more recently, Obamacare," he explained.

Jacobson also sees a certain amount of syncretism in the conspiracy movement—that is to say, places where the extreme left and right converge. Radicals of all backgrounds like to think of the world's problems as the intentional orchestrations of a secret cabal, a conspiracy bent on destroying free institutions.

This casts the Donald Trump phenomenon, as well as the widespread animus directed against immigrants, in a clearer light.

When describing illegal immigration from Mexico in his campaign announcement, Donald Trump infamously said, "When Mexico sends its people, they're not sending the best. They're not sending you. They're sending people that have lots of problems."

A conspiracy-minded Trump supporter does not hear the repeated use of "they" in that statement as a grammatical misstep. Instead, he or she hears it as an indication of a deliberate plot—a mysterious "they" that is threatening the nation.

Trump's insistence that he knows how the game is played taps into the collective psyche of his supporters—a psyche that views every loss of control as the result of a dark conspiracy. The conspiracy movement's robust online presence forces us to reckon with the reality that racist conspiracy theories predate Trump. They are pervasive, pernicious, and not going anywhere.

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Finding Refuge As the Tides Rise:
The Climate Migration Crisis

BY **ARJUN PRAKASH**

In May 2014, a man from Kiribati made the world's first refugee appeal based solely on the effects of climate change. He will not be the last. As the planet warms, where will people seek refuge? Arjun Prakash '19 investigates.

The World Reduced:
The Danger of Soundbite Culture

BY **ANA BARROS**

Jeb Bush gave an eleven minute interview, but most Americans would only hear seven seconds and two words: anchor babies. The internet has given us more access than ever to what candidates say, but we're still getting by on soundbites. Why? Ana Barros '18 explains.

More Money, More Problems
How Do We Fix Campaign Finance?

BY **SANOJA BHAUMIK**

In 2016, the Democratic and Republican nominees will go head to head for every last vote. And so will their Super PACs. Already, vaguely named entities like Priorities USA (Clinton) and Right to Rise (Bush) have raised hundreds of millions of dollars. Can we ever separate money from politics? Sanoja Bhaumik '19 looks to campaign finance laws in the rest of the world for the answer.

A Minor Revolution
The Catholic Church Promises Absolution for Abortions

BY **WILLIAM VESTER**

Pope Francis has declared that the Extraordinary Jubilee of Mercy will begin on December 8, meaning that, for one year, Catholics can seek forgiveness for extraordinary sins. And for the first time, abortion will be one of them. Add it to the list of Pope Francis' reforms but, as William Vester '19 asks, is this truly a radical change?

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